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*(Among companies with revenue scale of more than ₹15,000 million) in India in terms of revenue, growing at a CAGR of 31.26% from Fiscal 2024 to Fiscal 2026. (Source: 1Lattice Report) | # As of March 31, 2026

MILKY MIST DAIRY FOOD LIMITED is proposing, subject to applicable statutory and regulatory requirements, receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP with RoC, SEBI and the Stock Exchanges on August 4, 2026. The RHP is available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, and is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE and NSE at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively, on the website of the Company at www.milkmyst.com and the websites of the BRLMs, i.e., JM Financial Limited, **Axis Capital Limited** (formerly known as IFP Securities Limited) at www.axiscapital.in and www.ifpsec.com, respectively. Any potential investor should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see “Risk Factors” beginning on page 23 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP and should instead rely on their own examination of the Offer, including the risks involved, for making any investment decision. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the “U.S. Securities Act”) or any state securities laws in the United States and, unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, such Equity Shares are being offered and sold (i) outside of the United States in offshore transactions in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur; and (ii) within the United States to “qualified institutional buyers” (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act), pursuant to the private placement exemption set out in Section 4(a) of the U.S. Securities Act. The Equity Shares have not been and will not be registered, listed or otherwise qualified in any other jurisdiction outside India and may not be offered or sold, and Bids may not be made by persons in any such jurisdiction, except in compliance with the applicable laws of such jurisdiction. There will be no public offering in the United States.

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IN BRIEF



‘Rice scam’ in city: AAP; BJP points to Kejriwal-era ‘graft’

NEW DELHI
The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the BJP on Sunday traded corruption allegations. While the Opposition party claimed a “rice scam” in the city, the BJP pointed to “graft” during CM Arvind Kejriwal’s tenure, citing 24 CAG reports. » **Page 2**

‘JNU move tonix event on Khalid anti-student’

NEW DELHI
The Jawaharlal Nehru University Students’ Union on Sunday hit out at the JNU administration for cancelling a discussion on a book by former student Umar Khalid, calling it “anti-student”. » **Page 10**

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 17

Netanyahu rejects Trump’s 15-point proposal for Gaza

Israeli military will not withdraw from Gaza unless Hamas is ‘genuinely disarmed’, says the Israeli PM amid pressure from right-wing base ahead of election; willing to ‘challenge’ Trump, he adds

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Sunday rejected a U.S.-led Gaza plan endorsed by Hamas, putting distance between himself and U.S. President Donald Trump as he tries to shore up his base ahead of close elections.

After more than a week of gradually escalating criticism of the plan proposed by the Board of Peace, and despite receiving assurances that Israel would not need to start withdrawing from Gaza immediately, Mr. Netanyahu explicitly opposed the deal following pushback from his right-wing allies.

“Israel rejects the 15-point document,” Mr. Netanyahu said, referring to

Difference of opinions

The Israeli PM’s opposition to the proposal comes after more than a week of gradually escalating criticism of the plan

What the plan says:

■ Hamas would surrender weapons to a nascent Palestinian governing body

■ Israel would begin pulling out forces in tandem with the disarmament

They [U.S.] have ideas; some of them are acceptable to us and some are not, and we know how to stand our ground

BENJAMIN NETANYAHU
Israeli Prime Minister

the plan Hamas agreed to in late July.

The Israeli military “will not carry out any withdrawal until Hamas is genuinely disarmed, and will continue to thwart threats against our forces and our citizens”, he told a Cabinet meeting.

Mr. Netanyahu described Mr. Trump, who

had hailed the Gaza deal as a milestone for peace, as “our greatest friend in the White House”, but quickly made clear he was willing to challenge him, saying Israel was raising its objections with the United States.

“They have ideas; some of them are acceptable to us and some are not, and

we know how to stand our ground on these matters,” he said.

Mr. Netanyahu, Israel’s longest-serving leader, is running even or trailing in some polls ahead of October 27 elections, the country’s first since the devastating October 7, 2023 attack by Hamas that sparked the war on Gaza.

Polls show that the Gaza plan is unpopular with Mr. Netanyahu’s right-wing base, and far-right members of his Cabinet have urged him to kill it.

Hamas, days after selecting a new leader, Khalil al-Hayya, announced it supported the Gaza plan, and has since called on Washington to push Mr. Netanyahu to accept it.

Hamas in a statement said it was still committed to the plan.

Jharkhand govt. cancels 3 exams as protests continue

Suruchi Kumari
RANCHI

The Jharkhand government on Sunday agreed to cancel the 14th Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) preliminary examination and the JPSC backlog examinations held in 2023 and 2025 following discussions with protesting student groups.

The State’s Technical and Higher Education Minister, Sudivya Kumar, said the government had accepted “98% of the demands” of the protesting groups. The government also announced an Enforcement Directorate probe into alleged financial irregularities in the JPSC exam.

However, the students remained firm on their demand for a probe by the Central Bureau of Investigation into the alleged irregularities in the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combined Graduate Level (JSSC-CGL) examination and said the



A Jharkhand government delegation with student representatives at the State Guest House in Ranchi, after the meeting on Sunday. PTI

agitation would continue, including a march to the State Assembly on Monday. The announcement came even as all three JPSC members resigned and Chief Minister Hemant Soren assured protesters that “justice will be delivered with full transparency”.

‘No jurisdiction’

“The government has agreed with the demand for cancellation of the 14th JPSC and backlog examinations of 2023 and 2025,” Mr. Kumar said, adding that the State cannot recommend a CBI probe “as

we do not have jurisdiction over the JSSC-CGL exams that happened in line with High Court and Supreme Court directions”.

The protesting groups, led by Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM) and JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch, said they wanted cancellation of the JSSC-CGL and all exams connected to the TSR Data Processing Private Ltd., a blacklisted entity.

CONTINUED ON

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» **‘WILL SAFEGUARD FUTURE’**

» **PAGE 10**

Houthis hit Saudi oil facility, kill 11 in Yemen

Agence France-Presse
ADEN

At least 11 persons were killed in Houthi strikes in Yemen’s port city of Mokha on Sunday while a drone salvo by the Iran-aligned rebels targeted a Saudi Arabian oil refinery on the Kingdom’s Red Sea coast.

The attack in Mokha comes after a years-long truce in the civil war between the Houthis and the Saudi Arabia-backed, internationally recognised Yemeni government appeared to collapse as fighting between the rebels and the Kingdom in West Asia flared in recent weeks.

A medical source in Mokha said three civilians and eight military personnel had been killed in the

Houthi attack. Mokha is one of the main ports under Yemen’s internationally recognised government and has been renovated to handle shipping that avoids the Houthi-held port of Hodeida.

Two sources with the government forces earlier confirmed at least eight troops had been killed and more than 40 personnel were injured, saying that the Houthis attacked Mokha with several waves of missile and drones.

The Houthis’ military spokesperson Yahya Saree said the group targeted “Saudi enemy” troops and equipment in the area with missiles and drones.

CONTINUED ON

» **PAGE 10**

Almond season



Valley of plenty: Farmers collect almonds during the harvesting season at a village in Pulwama district of Jammu and Kashmir on Sunday. Almond cultivation is a key agricultural activity in the Kashmir Valley, contributing to the livelihoods of thousands of families. IMRAN NISSAR

J&K group flags ‘terror threat’ against Pandits

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

A Kashmir organisation on Sunday expressed concerns over purported on-line threats issued by terrorists to Pandits living in the Valley and demanded a probe, saying that the threats had “forced many minority community employees” working in the region to “go on leave”.

The Panun Kashmir, a Jammu-based organisation of Kashmiri Pandits, said the purported threat communication, dated August 7 and issued in the name of the United Liberation Council, “has specifically named members of the Kashmiri Pandit community and disclosed their telephone numbers”.

Scores of Pandits working in Kashmir have left the Valley after the fresh threat, sources say

Official sources said scores of Pandits working in Kashmir under the Prime Minister’s rehabilitation package had left the Valley in the face of the fresh threat. They said departments in “volatile and sensitive locations” in Kashmir had allowed Pandit employees to go on leave till August 20. However, there has been no official communication from the government.

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NATIONAL SONG ROW
Kerala Minister hints at withdrawing directive

STATES » PAGE 5



SLOGANS RAISED
Mamata faces protest in West Bengal district

NEWS » PAGE 11

Ladakh to lead Independent India’s first caste census

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Ladakh, one of the two youngest Union Territories in the country, is set to lead the way in demonstrating how caste will be enumerated for the first time in Independent India. The second phase of the Census – the Population Enumeration (PE) – which starts on August 17 in Ladakh and other snow-bound areas, is likely to ask questions on 40 parameters and provide an open-ended column for caste enumeration.

While the ongoing exercise is India’s first digital Census, officials are making an exception for Ladakh by printing a sufficient number of paper schedules. The move takes into account the presence of large defence establish-



Enumerators interact with residents during an awareness campaign in Birbhum, West Bengal, as part of the Census 2027. PTI

ments in the region bordering China and Pakistan, whose locations cannot be geo-tagged because of security concerns. The digital Census mandatorily requires enumerators to geo-locate the structures on a mobile App. Respondents who self-enumerate on Census portal are also required to do the same.

As reported by *The Hin-*

du on July 6, the rehearsal, or the “pre-test”, for the PE phase was conducted from July 1 to 20 in 16 States and Union Territories, where respondents, other than those from Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, recorded their castes in an “open column”, or the enumerator noted a resident’s caste as declared by them. The

methodology is likely to be retained in the final form.

Ladakh’s case is peculiar as it was not among these 16 States and Union Territories.

Though the questionnaire or the schedule is yet to be notified by the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India (RG&CCI), preparations have begun in Ladakh and snow-bound areas of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand to conduct PE from August 17 to September 30, ahead of the rest of the country, where the exercise will be conducted in February 2027. The Directorate of Census Operations, Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh, has concluded a three-day Master Trainers’ Training Programme for Census 2027 population enumera-

tion, marking the next phase of field preparedness.

According to Chief Principal Census Officer, Amit Sharma, the three-day programme provided comprehensive training on all aspects of Census 2027 population enumeration, covering census concepts, caste and demographic data collection, digital tools, self-enumeration, interviewing techniques, and hands-on use of the mobile application.

A senior government official said that, in the absence of the pre-test in Ladakh, the master-trainers are being trained based on tentative questions, around 40, which are likely to be notified this week.

CONTINUED ON

» **PAGE 10**

Police still harassing us, allege student protesters

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A former president of the Bhagat Singh Chhatra Ekta Manch alleged that Delhi Police personnel have been visiting her parents’ home in Delhi every seven to 10 days for several months, asking about her whereabouts and serving notices in connection with old cases, including defamation cases. Police scrutiny has continued long after the demonstrations ended, students told *The Hindu*, describing a sustained pattern of harassment.

DETAILS ON

» **PAGE 10**

INBRIEF



Sandhu directs govt. to frame rotation policy for officials

Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Sunday directed the Delhi government to frame a policy for the systematic rotation of officials and transfer those holding the same posts for long periods. Sources in Lok Niwas said he also instructed that vigilance officers be posted in all sensitive departments to ensure transparency and financial probity, and called for standard operating guidelines to monitor adherence to Chief Vigilance Commission norms.

High Court to hear ED plea against Kejriwal's bail today

The Delhi High Court will on Monday hear the Enforcement Directorate's (ED) plea challenging the bail granted to former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal in the 2021-22 excise policy-linked money laundering case. The petition, filed in 2024, is listed before Justice Manoj Jain. Mr. Kejriwal has been granted interim bail in the case by the Supreme Court, which referred questions on the "need and necessity of arrest" under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act to a larger Bench. Earlier, a trial court had granted him bail, but it was later stayed by the Delhi High Court. The ED and the CBI had arrested him in 2024.

Two policemen suspended after youth dies in Gurugram

Two policemen were suspended and an inquiry was initiated into the allegations of police negligence following the murder of 22-year-old Sagar in Farrukhnagar in Gurugram. A senior officer said head constable Ashok and constable Vinod were suspended after the victim's family alleged that timely action could have prevented the incident. The police said Sagar was shot dead during an assault at his home on August 6 by a group allegedly led by a man named Sachet.

Two killed, one injured in Dwarka Expressway accident

Two persons were killed and one seriously injured after the scooter they were riding rammmed a truck parked on the Dwarka Expressway, the police said on Sunday. The accident occurred around 8.30 p.m. on Saturday near BPTP Society. According to a complaint, the truck was parked in the middle of the flyover. An officer said an FIR has been registered and search is under way for the truck driver, adding that the heavy goods vehicle did not have reflectors.

'Rice scam' unfolding in Delhi: AAP; large-scale lapses under Kejriwal exposed by CAG: BJP

Govt. mum over 'racket' unearthed by Centre, Sirsa must resign, says Bharadwaj; Parvesh denies allegations; Food Supplies Minister threatens legal action, gives AAP 24 hours to issue an apology

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday traded corruption allegations, with the Opposition party alleging irregularities in the procurement and sale of subsidised rice meant for the poor in Delhi.

AAP claimed that the "racket" could involve rice worth ₹22,000 crore over three years. Public Works Department Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh denied the allegations and cited a Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) report tabled in the Assembly on August 7 that pointed to "large-scale financial irregularities" during AAP's 11-year tenure in the Capital.

31,000 tonnes of rice
Addressing a press conference, AAP Delhi unit president Saurabh Bharadwaj said that, on the recommendation of Food Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa's department, the Food Corporation of India had agreed to supply 31,000 tonnes of heavily subsidised rice every week to the North Eastern Regional Agricultural Marketing Corporation Limited in Assam for distribution among Delhi's poor for a period of three years.

"Instead, the corpora-



AAP Delhi chief Saurabh Bharadwaj alleged that rice meant for the poor is being diverted; Food Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa termed the allegations 'fabricated, malicious'. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP/ PTI

tion allegedly sold the rice to a private company in Haryana at nearly double the price, generating ₹70 crore to ₹71 crore in commission every week. At this rate, rice worth ₹22,000 crore would have been sold over three years, generating ₹11,000 crore in commission," Mr. Bharadwaj claimed.

He said the "racket" had been detected by the Central government's vigilance officials and that an officer had been suspended; however, the Delhi government had remained silent on the matter. Mr. Bharadwaj demanded that Chief Minister Rekha Gupta seek Mr. Sirsa's resignation and fix responsibility for the alleged scam.

Responding to the allegations, Mr. Sirsa threa-



tened legal action. He gave AAP leaders 24 hours to withdraw their allegations and issue a public apology, failing which he said he would initiate appropriate legal proceedings against them. "Saurabh Bharadwaj and Sanjeev Jha have today again made baseless, false, fabricated and malicious allegations against me, clearly intended to defame and malign me. Such a malicious campaign appears to be their *modus operandi*. Apologise or we will meet in court," Mr. Sirsa stated in a post on X.

'Ex-CM flouted rules'
The Delhi government said it had received 24 CAG reports in the past 18 months, with each "exposing corruption" involving thousands of crores of ru-

pees during AAP's tenure.

Citing the findings of a CAG report, the PWD Minister alleged that former CM Arvind Kejriwal had flouted rules, floated 1,185 manual tenders and inserted arbitration clauses in tenders, leading to large-scale irregularities and loss of public money.

'Outstanding liabilities'
"A total of ₹70,410 crore in tax revenue was outstanding against some businesses. The GST Department, in collusion with certain industrialists and business owners, allowed their outstanding GST liabilities to remain pending," Mr. Singh said.

He added that the CAG report stated that "bogus" e-way bills worth ₹68,680 crore had been generated.



Kanwariyas with idols of Lord Shiva; (below) CM Rekha Gupta showering flowers on pilgrims on Sunday. R. V. MORTHY/PTI

Gupta promises child beggar-free city, visits camps for kanwariyas

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The government will soon launch a 'child beggar-free Delhi' campaign to protect children found begging in public places and at major road intersections across the Capital, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has said.

In a video message posted on X on Saturday, Ms. Gupta said the campaign would be implemented across all 13 districts to provide a secure future to children involved in begging.

She added that children would not be removed from the streets by force. "Instead, the government, in coordination with the Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights and non-governmental organisations, would counsel their families, understand their difficulties and provide alternatives," she said.

"The drive will also help us identify and prosecute organised gangs that are forcing children into begging and help secure their



future," the CM added.

Welcoming pilgrims

She also visited Kanwar service camps in Mayapuri and Pitampura to review arrangements and welcomed *kanwariyas* by showering them with flowers.

In a release, Ms. Gupta stated that there is a deep sense of reverence and respect for *kanwariyas* who arrive in Delhi carrying Ganga water. The government is committed to ensuring that every Shiva devotee passing through the Capital gets a safe, smooth and comfortable environment, the CM added.

Body of man swept away in drain found

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The body of an 18-year-old man who was swept away by rainwater in a drain in south-east Delhi's Priyanka Camp area was retrieved from Agra canal on Sunday, the police said.

The body of Ankit, a resident of Bhim Colony, was

retrieved during a search operation carried out by rescue teams from the Delhi Disaster Management Authority and the Delhi Fire Services, the police added.

The incident took place on Friday evening near the Priyanka Camp drain in Madanpur Khadar amid heavy rain.

Board-based admissions at 2 DU colleges highlight limits of centralised system

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

Two women's colleges of Delhi University (DU) have begun admitting students on the basis of their Class 12 board exam results after nearly 2,000 seats remained vacant under the university's centralised admission process through the Common University Entrance Test (CUET).

The separate admission process at Aditi Mahavidyalaya in Bawana and Bhagini Nivedita College (BNC) near Najafgarh has brought into focus the difficulties faced by colleges that were established to serve students from rural and semi-urban areas. Aditi Mahavidyalaya has filled no more than 40% of its seats since CUET came into effect in 2022.

It has around 1,000 seats lying vacant while BNC has 985 unfilled seats. Last year, DU conducted a mop-up round based on



Bhagini Nivedita College has 985 vacant seats. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

board results to fill vacant seats across the university. This year, for the first time, it has allowed the two colleges to conduct admissions separately.

"We granted permission for separate admissions because seats were not being filled. This is primarily because the colleges are on the outskirts," a DU official said. Admissions are being conducted online and offline, with both colleges having completed their first round on Friday.

Aditi Mahavidyalaya principal Neelam Rath said centralised systems

Radha, 17, who secured admission to Aditi Mahavidyalaya, said she had not appeared for CUET. "Our teachers never told us about CUET," she said.

Another student from Bawana said CUET information in her school was directed mainly at high-performing students.

Meanwhile, Sumaiya Khan, 18, from Rampur in Uttar Pradesh, said despite scoring 93% in her board exams, she could not secure admission to a DU college because of the subject-mapping requirements.

A Class 12 science student, she wanted to pursue humanities. "My school did not have arts subjects, so I took science. I appeared for humanities subjects in CUET and then realised that this made me ineligible for DU colleges," she said.

On the basis of her board results, she has now secured a seat in the BA Programme at BNC.

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MONDAY, AUG. 10
RISE 05:48 SET 19:05
RISE 02:40 SET 17:23
TUESDAY, AUG. 11
RISE 05:48 SET 19:04
RISE 03:52 SET 18:13
WEDNESDAY, AUG. 12
RISE 05:49 SET 19:04
RISE 05:03 SET 18:55

Delhi Weather
Delhi City 35 26
Safdarjang 35 26
Palam 34 25

Delhi Palam Today
33°C The weather will be warm and uneasy. Night will be comfortable. Few spells of moderate rain and thunder-shower to occur.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
31°C The weather will be slight warm. Few spells of moderate rain & thundershower to occur. Night will be comfortable.

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2. All other terms and conditions of the advertisement shall remain unchanged.
3. For further details, candidates may visit the official website of PWD, Government of Tripura at https://pwd.tripura.gov.in.
Joint Secretary, PWD
Government of Tripura
ICA/D/738/26

Office of the Commandant 25th Battalion SAF, Bhopal
No.-25th Bn/Petrolpump/3089/2026, Dated: 07/08/2026
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Bid proposals are invited from reputed manufactures & vendors for the supply, installation and commissioning of following item at police petrol pump operational at 25th Battalion SAF, Bhadbhada road, Bhopal.
S. No. Name of Item Approximate amount Earnest Money Deposit Cost of Bid Document Period of Contract
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Interested bidders can view the MP Tender Portal on website https://mptenders.gov.in/ & MP Police Portal on website https://www.mppolice.gov.in/en/tenders.
1. The Bid Document can be downloaded only online from 10:00 AM (time) (date) 08/08/2026 to 16:00 (time) (date) 22/08/2026.
2. Bid schedule:
Start date of bid submission: - 10:00 AM (time) (date) 08/08/2026.
Last date of bid submission:16:00 PM (time) (date) 22/08/2026.
Technical bid Opening - 16:30 PM (time) (date) 24/08/2026.
3. Amendments to NIT, if any, would be published on website https://mptenders.gov.in 02 national, 02 state level and 02 local newspaper and https://www.mppolice.gov.in/en/tenders
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In this regard, objections, if any, are invited from manufacturers, authorized distributors, or suppliers who manufacture or market similar items that are compatible with the above-mentioned equipment and capable of delivering the intended performance/results. Such objections, along with supporting documentary evidence, if any, may be submitted through email at the address mentioned below on or before 21.08.2026 up to 02:00 PM.
Email: mmo@skimsme.edu.in.
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BREZZA

INBRIEF



Amit Shah presents President's Colour to Puducherry Police

Union Home Minister Amit Shah presented the President's Colour to Puducherry Police on Sunday and praised the force for its commitment and dedication in ensuring the country's internal security. In his address, Mr. Shah said the new criminal laws are based on the "three pillars of technology, timeline, and trust". The President's Colour is the highest honour given to a military unit or police force of a State or Union Territory. The Home Minister also flagged off the 'Har Ghar Tiranga' yatra at Rajiv Gandhi Square. Carrying a 40-foot national flag, hundreds of BJP members marched together in the procession.

Bihar CM announces panel for examination reforms

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Sunday announced several measures to strengthen the State's education system, including setting up a State-level committee to ensure quality education in schools and examination reforms, and introducing AI-based assessments. Addressing a two-day State-level workshop organised by the Education Department in Patna, Mr. Choudhary said the State government is committed to making education more qualitative, student-centric, transparent, and technology-driven. PTI

Kerala schoolteacher suspended over quiz question on Savarkar

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Kerala General Education Department has suspended a teacher who was involved in preparing a controversial question that identified Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) ideologue V.D. Savarkar as the freedom fighter who received the "most punishment" from the British in a quiz conducted for school students in Kasaragod. Guru Prasad, a teacher at A.U.P.S. Pallathadukka,

has been suspended pending inquiry.

Detailed inquiry
The Director of General Education had directed the Deputy Director of Education, Kasaragod, to initiate disciplinary proceedings against the teacher and conduct a detailed inquiry. The controversy arose from the Social Science Club's 'Freedom Quiz 2026,' conducted at the school level on August 6. The lower primary quiz contained 15 questions and

five tie-breaker questions. The fifth question was, "Who is the freedom fighter who received the most punishment from the hands of the British?". The answer given in the answer key was V.D. Savarkar. According to the order, the questions were prepared by a group of teachers under the leadership of Mr. Prasad. The inquiry found that framing a question in a manner that could spread a misleading impression was "very serious".

SPOTLIGHT

Rahul Karmakar

Tamuli Gaon, a village in eastern Assam's Jorhat district, is about 40 km west of neighbouring Sivasagar district's Bihubar, the epicentre of destruction by one of Assam's worst localised floods since the 1950s. The gushing waters that submerged much of Sivasagar and adjoining Charaideo districts on July 19-20 lost momentum by the time they reached the periphery of Tamuli Gaon, but inundated the surrounding, low-lying paddy fields, to turn this village of 110 families into an island. Biju Kumar Sarmah, a teacher in the village nicknamed Gopuli for his obsession with plantation drives to "reclaim what's lost", explains why Tamuli Gaon was spared. "The water did not have enough force to cut through the embankments in our area, unlike those a few kilometres to the east, toward Sivasagar district," he says. He is not sure whether the distance from Bihubar would provide Tamuli Gaon with insurance against a bigger disaster, with at least two more months of rain to go. "The floodwaters have less than half the distance to travel from Bihubar to Tamuli Gaon than from Mon to Bihubar," he says. Mon, the headquarters

of Nagaland's district of the same name, bore the brunt of extremely heavy rainfall that drenched parts of Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, and Nagaland from July 18 to 22. The rainfall triggered landslides, killing 11 people in Mon town, and large volumes of water from five major rivers and numerous streams originating in Mon district gushed downstream, carrying earth and debris, to swamp more than 80% of Sivasagar and Charaideo districts. "The water trickled gently around noon on July 19. It suddenly became a *mahapralay* (total destruction), and before we could understand what was happening, we were being thrashed about in neck-deep water," says Shivraj Sharma of Bihubar Nepalkhuti, a village near the Assam-Nagaland border that was home to about 200 families of mostly dairy farmers. The Sivasagar, Charaideo, and Jorhat district authorities, too, were caught unawares by the deluge. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, after touring the flood-hit districts, admitted that the administration in each could not mobilise rescue and relief operations for seven days since the disaster struck. He said this was understandable, as these districts do not have a history of major floods and the authorities were not as disaster-ready as other dis-

A flood of woes in Assam

The scale of devastation by one of the State's worst localised floods that occurred at an unprecedented speed has increased the challenge of recovering from the shock, with 101 dead and 7.21 lakh people affected



Residents being evacuated from the waterlogged Rukminigaon area of Guwahati. RITU RAJ KONWAR

tricts that experience floods regularly. These three districts accounted for 71 of the 101 people who died in the floods across 16 districts from April to August 9, 2026, and more than 94% of some 7.21 lakh flood-affected people. Disaster management experts explained why the government machinery was underprepared in the three districts. "There's a flaw in the government's approach to disaster management, which is to identify risks and concentrate on high-risk areas. The planning needs to change.

If low or zero-risk areas become high-risk overnight, there's very little people can do, as was the case with the three districts," says Partha Jyoti Das, a climate, water, and disaster specialist with Assam-based biodiversity conservation group Aaranyak. He says getting the right people for climate-smart or climate-resilient flood management is crucial. "Ditto with factoring in fluctuating climate change scenarios in everything to minimise disasters." When the National Green Tribunal banned

Meghalaya's hazardous rat-hole coal mining in April 2014, green activists in Assam sought attention to similar, potentially "more dangerous", activities along the State's borders with Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland. **Mining menace** A 2018 PIL plea filed by Congress leader Debabrata Saikia, then a party MLA from Nazira, in the Gauhati High Court indicated rampant coal mining was not the only source of disaster for Sivasagar and adjoining districts. It conveyed that

illegal sand and stone mining and encroachment of fragile river beds were inviting trouble. It focussed on the Dikhow, Sivasagar's lifeline-turned-sorrow, seeking an immediate ban on the potentially catastrophic riverbed mining. Following the court's directive, the government sent teams from January to March 2019 to verify the allegations, concentrating on Bihubar and adjoining areas near the Assam-Nagaland border. The inquiry revealed eight stone quarries, 81 stone crushers, and the seizure of about 10,000 cubic metres of minor minerals in the area. The report described Bihubar and the surrounding areas as a hub of mining, distribution, supply, and interstate transportation. It also said that most of the gravel and boulders were transported from Nagaland. Sivasagar MLA and Rajor Dal president Akhil Gogoi was more vocal about the "indiscriminate" coal and stone mining. "Rainwater accumulated in the hollowed coal pits in Nagaland, eventually burst out and caused widespread devastation in Assam," he says, also pointing to the "rape of the rivers" by the mining mafia. His Sivasagar-based party leader Manas Konwar went a step further, naming two local BJP legislators, one of them a Minister, as the kingpins of the stone and coal mining operations along the

Assam-Nagaland border. While the Assam Chief Minister, speaking to the media, denied any mining activities in Assam, community-based organisations in Nagaland rejected "theories" that their hill State and their people were responsible for Assam's floods. **Post-flood trauma** Sivasagar was formerly known as Rangpur, the administrative and political capital of the Ahoms, who ruled large swathes of Assam for 600 years until the British took control of the region in the early 1800s. Historians say Sivasagar (Charaideo was carved out of it in August 2015) was strategic for the Ahoms to administer a vast region, and that the region was relatively flood-free compared to the rest of the Brahmaputra Valley. The Ahom royal chronicles refer to flooding in and around the capital at intervals of more than a hundred years, including in 1691 and 1793. "Sivasagar's misery indicates that the flood cycle may have reduced (after the last one recorded 60 years ago) and become more catastrophic due to several factors, mostly man-made. The unpredictable climate change scenario is adding to this misery, making old water discharge data on which flood control measures are designed redundant," says

Bibhash Sarma, an engineering teacher and consultant to Assam's Water Resources Department. Aaranyak's Das adds that the ever-changing rainfall pattern is the new normal. "The administrative machinery must understand that no part of Assam or anywhere else in the northeast is safe from floods and associated disasters. Everyone, down to the farmer, needs to be wired to anticipate such calamities during the six rainy months in the region." District officials say the challenges in the areas returning to normality include clearing several feet of silt and debris from houses and paddy fields, sanitising the foul-smelling flood-hit areas, and ensuring adequate healthcare for livestock and people vulnerable to water- and vector-borne diseases such as Japanese encephalitis, which claimed 19 lives this year, before the floods. The biggest challenge could be the trauma of expecting the worst in a State that recorded 160 and 181 human deaths during the 2017 and 2022 floods, respectively. "I don't think anyone in Jorhat, Sivasagar, or Charaideo can sleep peacefully, at least during the remaining two months of the monsoon this year," says Sarmah, whose Tamuli Gaon village is 18 km south of the Brahmaputra. *rahul.karmakar@thehindu.co.in*

Amid 'dissent' in Punjab BJP, Dhillon meets Nabin

Discussed strategy for 2027 Assembly election, says State party chief: Congress questions Akali Dal's 'desperate' bid for tie-up with BJP, says both parties will have no chance of victory if they join hands

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH

Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillon on Sunday said he held a key meeting in Delhi with the party's national president, Nitin Nabin, and discussed the strategy for the 2027 Assembly poll and steps to strengthen the party organisation. The Punjab BJP president and State organisation secretary Manthri Srinivasulu were summoned on Saturday amid dissent among sections of party leaders that accused the State leadership of sidelining the old cadre during the recent organisational reshuffle, sources said. Launching a sharp attack on the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government, he said Punjab is "grappling with crises such as the scourge of drugs, deteriorating law and order, and the migration of youth abroad, but the ruling party has no concrete solution to these problems". He said the BJP is committed to making Punjab a safe, prosperous, and pro-



Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillon (left) said talks to strengthen the State unit were held with party president Nitin Nabin. FILE PHOTO

gressive State once again, and that the organisation is being strengthened down to every village and booth in pursuit of this goal. Meanwhile, State Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring on Sunday asked why Shiromani Akali Dal chief Sukhbir Singh Badal was so "desperate" for an electoral alliance with the BJP that he had to make a "U-turn" on a sensitive matter like delimitation of Assembly and parliamentary constituencies. The remark came a day after the Akali Dal demanded that Parliament pass the

women's reservation Bill and the delimitation Bill with a uniform 50% increase in seats for States so that they are implemented without further delay. The party announced its revised stand on the issue after Mr. Badal's recent meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Delhi. Mr. Warring reminded Mr. Badal that the party had strongly opposed the delimitation bill in April. "So, what changed within these three months that you started seeing merit in the same Bill that you otherwise found against Pun-

jab's interests?" he said. Mr. Warring asserted that even if the Akalis and the BJP come together for the election, they stand "absolutely no chance of victory". "The people of Punjab have neither forgotten the sacrilege nor the atrocities on farmers that the two parties are respectively guilty of," he alleged. Senior Congress MLA Sukhpal Singh Khaira on Sunday urged Speaker Kultar Singh Sandhwan to extend the Assembly session to allow adequate discussion on six Bills listed for consideration. The Bills, which include proposals related to three digital universities, GST, and out-sourced and contractual employees, were introduced at the fag end of the session, Mr. Khaira said.

'Serious job crisis' Meanwhile, Akali Dal leader Daljit Singh Cheema demanded that the AAP government issue a White Paper on the employment and recruitment situation, alleging that Punjab is facing a "serious employment and service-related crisis".

Mayawati opposes 'creamy layer' in quotas for SCs, STs

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW



BSP president Mayawati

Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) chief Mayawati on Sunday opposed the 'creamy layer' concept in reservations for Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs), arguing that affirmative action is linked to social transformation, economic emancipation, and self-respect. She also criticised the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) for "politicising" the issue. "For the SC and ST sections, which have been divided, oppressed and marginalised for centuries, it [reservation] becomes a crucial issue, especially when caste-based hatred, exploitation, torture, injustice and atrocities show no signs of abating," wrote Ms. Mayawati on X. She said creamy layer for SCs and STs is "against the objectives" laid down by the Constitution. The BSP president questioned RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat over his recent remarks that reservation had been politicised, creating bitterness in society, and that beneficiaries should voluntarily give up the benefits. She termed the

RSS's position a reflection of a "casteist mindset". **'Casteist mindset'** "While the RSS chief recently reiterated his statement that, 'Reservation has been deliberately politicised, leading to bitterness in society, and that beneficiaries of reservation should voluntarily give up its benefits.' In reality, this is a casteist mindset that may serve narrow political interests, but undermines constitutional objectives," she added in the post. "Reservation is essentially meant to provide the constitutional and legal right to equality on humanitarian grounds to millions of exploited, oppressed, neglected, and despised people who have been victims of the caste system for centuries."

In Pradhan's ouster, BJD sees chance to regain lost ground

NEWS ANALYSIS

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

The resignation of Dharmaendra Pradhan as Union Education Minister following protests by students in Delhi last month has marked a notable shift in national politics. For Odisha's principal Opposition party – the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) – the development has signalled a chance to reclaim lost ground. The BJD's renewed confidence appears to stem from conversations on the



Naveen Patnaik's BJD appears upbeat based on public mood, which is critical of development under the BJP govt. FILE PHOTO

ground that reflect dissatisfaction over the pace of development under the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

After the setback in the 2024 Assembly election, the BJD ceded more ground to the BJP, losing three Rajya Sabha seats, while its strength in the Assembly dropped from 51 to 42 following the defection of eight MLAs during the Rajya Sabha election. Despite these developments, political observers note that the Naveen Patnaik-led party's disintegration is far below what was anticipated after 24 years of uninterrupted rule and the accumulated weight of anti-incumbency. The exodus, though notable, also falls short of the turbulence seen in other regional parties such as the Trinamool Congress and the Shiv Sena (UBT).

'Were never in doubt' "We were never in doubt about our ability to bounce back as a strong regional force. We knew the new BJP government would eventually struggle under the weight of public expectations. It clearly lacks the capability to sustain the pace of development Odisha witnessed under Naveen Patnaik," said BJD's senior vice-president Debi Prasad Mishra. Veteran journalist Rabi

Das echoed the concern. He said the distribution of error-ridden school textbooks affecting lakhs of students has been one of the "most glaring administrative failures" of the Mohan Charan Majhi regime. The "deteriorating" law and order situation has dented the government's image. Meanwhile, the BJP has placed heavy emphasis on announcing investments. Political observers, however, note that such announcements have had limited impact as they do not translate into immediate improvements in people's living conditions.



Auto driver, friend 'sexually assault' two children in A.P.

Protest held in A.P. against seafarer deaths in war zones

'Mastermind' in illegal explosives case arrested

The agency had also searched quarry-related locations in Kozhikode, Kasaragod and Kannur districts before arresting the suspects.

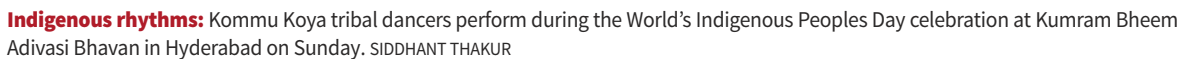
BJP, JD(S) launch march against Bidadi Township project

Ladakh hoteliers seek mandatory resident papers for registration

Video of BJP leader's Bidadi issue remarks goes viral

The video showed a casual conversation between Karnataka Minister Madhu Bangarappa and Mr. Vijayendra, who is also the MLA of Shikaripur, at a drought review meeting held in Shikaripur on Saturday.

Cultural showcase



A.P. govt. will protect rights of tribal youth, says Naidu

Struck down by SC

The GO No. 3, issued in 2000 to reserve 100% of teacher posts in the Scheduled Areas for the local tribal candidates, was

As many as 1.5 lakh tribal youth would be provided skill training, while special initiatives would be taken to prepare tribal students for competitive examinations, he said.

Combined effects of climate and geology caused 2024 Wayanad landslide: study

corded in the Western Ghats. It was conducted by researchers from the University of Kerala, Indian Institute of Science Education and Research (IISER) Mohali, and Savitribai Phule Pune University.

To understand why the landslide became so destructive, the researchers conducted extensive field investigations across the affected valley in April 2025. Geological mapping was carried out from Chooral-



Shifting sands

Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye will struggle to create credible deterrent

The joint defence agreement, signed by Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye in Mecca on August 7 reflects their shared strategic anxieties and the changes under way in West Asia's security architecture. The three countries have pledged to bolster collective security and deterrence, and promised to treat an armed attack against one as an attack against all. On paper, this is a formidable alliance. Pakistan is a nuclear-armed country with a powerful military; Saudi Arabia, one of the world's largest crude oil exporters, has deep pockets and considerable influence across the Muslim world; and Türkiye has an expanding military industrial base, including advanced drone production capabilities. That the pact was announced in the middle of the war on Iran and Israel's continuing bombing campaigns in the region is no coincidence. Faced with the prospect of reduced American strategic presence in West Asia, regional powers have begun looking beyond the traditional U.S. security umbrella for new partnerships. In September 2025, a few weeks after Israel bombed Qatar, Pakistan and Saudi Arabia announced a bilateral defence agreement. The war on Iran, which saw Tehran retaliating by striking U.S. bases across the Persian Gulf, and Israel's wars in its neighbourhood, have further deepened the security concerns of Saudi Arabia and Türkiye. They have now decided to turn the page on their often fraught relationship and build a trilateral framework with Pakistan, which fought a short aerial war with India in May 2025.

This agreement shows the growing appetite of regional powers for formal security pacts. Türkiye, which has long sought a bigger role in West Asia, will gain more strategic space. Pakistan, traditionally a South Asian regional power overshadowed by India, is also seeking to expand its role as a West Asia security provider and mediator. The alliance would allow the three countries to deepen defence cooperation and military interoperability though it is too early to say whether it would help them address their security challenges. Alliances based on collective security, such as NATO and CSTO, are generally formed to build deterrence against conflicts. The biggest liability of the Mecca Agreement is that it was signed amid ongoing wars. Over the past five months, Saudi Arabia has faced repeated Iranian missile and drone attacks. The collective security pledge is unlikely to deter Iran from targeting U.S. bases in Saudi Arabia if the war, currently on pause, escalates further. Existing conflicts, therefore, make the promise of collective defence largely symbolic from the very outset. So, the credibility of the Mecca Agreement will ultimately depend on whether the three partners can turn their political commitment into a credible deterrent, which is currently non-existent.

Podium finish

India's women boxers were the highlight of the Glasgow Commonwealth Games

In the truncated Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, India performed well, exceeding expectations and retaining fourth place behind developed nations such as Australia, England, and Canada, despite a sharp drop in medals from 61 to 39, including 13 gold, 17 silver, and nine bronze. The gold rush on the penultimate day, powered by the spectacular performance of the boxers who won seven gold and three silver medals, improved India's position. While some weight classes had weaker draws, several categories posed strong challenges. Propelled by determination and hard work, five women boxers – Sakshi Chaudhary, Preeti Pawar, Jaismine Lamboria, Priya Ghanghas, and Arundhati Choudhary – and two men, Sachin Siwach and Ankush Panghal, ensured India's best-ever showing of 10 medals, three more than that in the last edition. The women boxers' fearless approach established them as a force to reckon with. India won 16 medals in athletics and para-athletics, with notable contributions from para-athletes Dilip Gavit, Soman Rana, and Sharmila Dhankar. In world-class fields, the country's athletes won 10 medals compared to eight in Birmingham 2022. Neeraj Chopra recovered from injury to take a creditable silver and lead the country to twin-medal glory in javelin along with Yashvir Singh and underlined India's rising status as a javelin powerhouse. Other moments to cherish included triple jumpers Praveen Chithravel and Selva Prabhu's twin podium finishes, Gulveer Singh becoming the first Indian to medal in 5000m and 10000m, Murali Sreeshankar winning his second straight long jump silver, Tejaswin Shankar claiming the country's first-ever decathlon medal, and Sarvesh Kushare pocketing a high jump silver.

Asmita Dey and Harsh Singh sprang a surprise by winning the country's first gold medals in judo, while Mirabai Chanu lived up to her billing to clinch her third successive gold medal. She led Indian lifters to a significant haul of eight medals. The country's strong show, against an expectation of around 30 medals, helped the contingent leave Glasgow on a high as Ahmedabad prepares to host a bigger Games offering more medals in 2030. Indian athletes' praiseworthy performance in Glasgow has raised hopes for the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games next month, where a bigger haul is expected from a wider range of disciplines. While India is capable of securing impressive medal collections at the Commonwealth and Asian Games, it needs to raise its level manifold to be counted among the best globally. Aspiring to host the 2036 Olympics, it must identify priority sports and invest in them to ensure a higher finish, even while waging a perennial war against doping.

On July 20, 2026, India's young people came together to demand a fair education system and accountability for paper leaks.

These young women and men came from every caste, class, region and religion. They were brave enough to demand justice, wise enough to know their Constitutional rights, tender enough to laugh at their own turmoil, and earnest enough to believe that they could fight and win.

The nation watched the protesters in awe, as they sang, danced, laughed, held hands and stood together. Their resistance gave voice to the pain both of their own generation, and of crores of Indians who are suffering but have been silenced by fear.

Met with violence

The protests carried forward India's proud legacy of peaceful resistance, a tradition which won it independence and is protected by Article 19 of the Constitution.

Yet, the government tried to crush the youth's voice with a brutal assault. They were attacked with tear gas shells, beaten with nail-studded lathis and shot with pellet guns.

Nineteen-year-old Sahil Lochab, whom I met, had hundreds of lead pellets lodged all over his upper body. A pellet struck his eye, likely blinding him. Policemen wielding batons brutally assaulted young women, injuring many on their

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Rahul Gandhi

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Member of Parliament for Rae Bareilly, Uttar Pradesh, and Member of the Indian National Congress

Five hundred metres from Parliament, students were brutally attacked by forces which report to one man

private parts. Minors were beaten with lathis, their bones broken, gashes and bruises on their bodies. In Bihar, student protesters were shot with firearms, including an AK-47, in Siwan, leaving many severely injured.

Who authorised this illegal and unconstitutional violence?

Centralised power

The Narendra Modi government prides itself on its centralised control. Whether it is a mission to Mars or an Olympic medal, it repeatedly trumpets that the credit is due to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah. Nothing moves without their approval.

The violence happened in the heart of Delhi, barely 500 metres from Parliament. Both the security forces deployed, the Delhi Police and the Rapid Action Force (RAF), report directly to the Home Minister.

There are only two possibilities. First, he authorised the attack on the students – in which case he is culpable. Second, he had no idea that it was taking place – which means that he is entirely incompetent. Either way, as Home Minister, what happened on that day is his responsibility, and he must resign.

Instead, his inaction proves that he approves of the attack on students. He has not ordered any inquiry or even issued a statement. He has refused to come to Parliament, and motions filed

A new security triangle emerges with the Makkah Pact

The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement (MJDA), signed on August 7, 2026, by the top leaders of Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan, is the first regional realignment since the geostrategic tsunami of the United States-Iran war. While the MJDA text has not been revealed, the joint statement issued specifically states that “any armed attack against any one of the three states shall be regarded as an attack against them all”.

This echoes infamous Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) – never invoked – leading speculators to claim that the MJDA was a harbinger of a “Muslim NATO”. It appears to be part of a jerky Saudi response to specific security challenges, including a Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement (SMDA) with Pakistan last year and a 14-country Multinational Maritime Defence Alliance (MMDA) in the last week of July.

Shifting alignments, uncertain stakes

Any analysis of the MJDA faces multiple uncertainties, including ongoing regional turbulence, partners' previous karma, and their varied expectations. This hazy context creates a push-pull effect: from anticipation of the MJDA having profound cascading implications to it being a seemingly desultory, inconsequential response to their asymmetric defence and security challenges. Some also see it as inducing counter-polarisation and alarming other stakeholders from Iran and its non-state allies, Israel, Kurds, and Greece to the United Arab Emirates and India. To walk back, the Saudi Deputy Foreign Minister has clarified that it is neither an effort to establish a military axis nor a sectarian bloc. He denied any link to nuclear ambitions or an arms race.

This denial is unlikely to pierce the statement's conspicuous silence about the precise threats that the MJDA is geared to confront, the U.S.-Iran war roiling the region, Israeli aggressiveness, threats from the non-state actors, and the impact of choke point constrictions. It also refrains from either inviting like-minded regional powers to join in or an uplink with the existing collective security architectures provided by the Arab League, the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation and the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC).

Observers point out that the Arab-Muslim world has remained divided against Israel for close to eight decades. Hence, the prospect of the MJDA being a precursor to a Muslim NATO polarised against Iran and its Arab proxies appears far-fetched at this stage. Moreover, even as all three MJDA signatories are allies of the U.S. (which remains suspiciously silent), it is unclear if it is meant to substitute the regional Pax Americana or to serve as a surrogate for the *ancien régime*. In the same vein, if the proposed Muslim NATO in future decides to confront Israel, the U.S. would have scored its own goal.

Moreover, the MJDA is beset by various snags. The Saudis have bitter memories of the Ottoman



Mahesh Sachdev

Retired Indian Ambassador, specialising in the Arab world and oil issues

rule, which brutally suppressed the Al-Saud. For similar reasons, from Türkiye, Ankara's boots on the ground have been shunned by most post-independence Arab regimes.

Till recently, Türkiye promoted the Sunni outfits such as the Muslim Brotherhood, Hamas and motley Syrian militias, many of which are anathema to the Gulf regimes. Türkiye's President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan's Neo-Ottoman ambitions to lead the Sunni Islamic world collide with the Kingdom's self-image of being the Custodian of Islam's Two Holiest Shrines. Riyadh does not contenance playing second fiddle to Turkey or any other Muslim power. President Erdoğan had a testy relationship with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman (Mbs) over the 2018 murder of Jamal Khashoggi, a U.S.-based Saudi journalist, in the Saudi consulate in Istanbul. Turkish leaks on this episode sullied Mbs's image, making him a western outlier.

On the other hand, Pakistani troop deployments in Saudi Arabia in the past resulted in frictions due to chain of command disputes, Islamabad's refusal to have its troops shorn of Shias and its reluctance to confront Iran or Yemen. Armed forces in Türkiye and Pakistan have a long-standing tradition of Bonapartism. Saudis have kept armed forces and the National Guard, both with an American-styled set up, out of politics since the Ikhwani militia insurrection (the late 1920s) and the Makkah siege of 1979. Both Türkiye and Pakistan have an active border with Iran – offering a potentially lucrative post-war economic bonanza that they would be loath to forego. Pakistan's enthusiasm for the MJDA is circumscribed by its 900 kilometre-long border with Iran, a large Shia minority, internal security challenges and hostility with India and Afghanistan. In a typical doublespeak, last week, Pakistan began formal discussions on a Free Trade Agreement with Iran, notwithstanding the U.S. sanctions, the MJDA and the SMDA.

Riyadh's security needs

The MJDA is clearly fulcrumed around Saudi security requirements, which Riyadh expects Türkiye and Pakistan to mitigate as part of a “friends with benefits” arrangement. However, the current threats faced by Saudi Arabia are complex and asymmetric, ranging from air attacks on its vital and vulnerable oil and civil infrastructure by Iran and its proxies, the closures of the Strait of Hormuz and Bab al-Mandeb and the possible insurrection by the restive Shia minority. It is unclear if Türkiye and Pakistan can meet such challenges, where the U.S. Central Command, with its large, long-standing presence and state-of-the-art equipment, failed. The new allies could perhaps upstage the U.S. in having more boots on the ground in Saudi Arabia, but the Kingdom is unlikely to face a ground invasion. Moreover, relying on foreign forces to address internal security challenges would be bad optics for the

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daily by the Opposition asking for a discussion have been summarily rejected.

At the same time, Prime Minister Modi, desperate to protect his image, has activated his propaganda machinery and *Godi* media. First information reports and detentions of young protesters continue, in order to intimidate them. The Bharatiya Janata Party's online trolls threaten young female protesters and their parents, forcing them to issue public apologies. Prime Minister Modi personally made a video “forgiving” the youth of India for exercising their legitimate right to express themselves. How absurd it is for a Prime Minister to forgive his own people when they are demanding accountability.

Standing with India's youth

Since Prime Minister Modi is clearly so out of touch, let me warn him – young people across the country have awakened. His image is destroyed and can never be rebuilt. The youth of India will not allow him, Home Minister Shah, or any official to escape the consequences of their actions. We in the Opposition stand with the youth. We will not allow these crimes to pass unpunished.

On July 20, 2026, Sahil and thousands of young people across India demanded accountability from those they elected to office. Sooner or later, they will get that accountability. And we will ensure it.

Kingdom. The foregoing is not to deride the MJDA as merely a cosmetic exercise. It symbolises the congruence of the three large Sunni powers with considerable complementarity: the Saudi \$83 billion defence budget, Türkiye's booming military industrial complex exporting \$10 billion annually and Pakistan's 6,60,000-strong armed forces. Their defence and security cross-pollination through military exercises, interoperability of weapon systems and co-production and development of hardware would be beneficial to them all. Additionally, Türkiye and Pakistan could gain political influence in the Kingdom and enrich themselves.

At this stage, the MJDA's future appears uncertain. It may flourish if a low-burn attrition war continues to ripple through the region. Ironically, if an all-out shooting war breaks out, Türkiye and Pakistan may be hesitant to commit forces against Iran, their neighbour. At the other end, if peace prevails, the MJDA would become superfluous. A market share scrimmage among the oil exporters would create a glut, affecting the Saudi capacity to bankroll the MJDA partners.

Having suffered Iranian doggedness and Trumpian tantrums, Saudi Arabia and other Gulf Arabs are currently experimenting with various security alternatives. The Saudis began the SMDA with Pakistan last year and have felt the need for an MMDA and MJDA. They do not appear to be playing a zero-sum game between semi-reliable Pakistan and India. U.S. President Donald Trump's unreliability was on full display to the Saudis recently in his last-minute Abraham Accords rider to the recent nuclear agreement with the Kingdom. The Saudis may not wish to further complicate their dependence on Uncle Sam by deepening their entanglement with Ankara and Islamabad, both ultimately subject to Washington's dictates.

The implications for India

Depending on various scenarios panning out, the MJDA can impact India's interests in multiple ways. While India needs to keep a steely eye on Pakistan's attempt to align the MJDA partners with it against India, New Delhi should not overreact. As the world's third-largest crude oil importer, India is slated to drive global demand for the next 15 years. India has been the Kingdom's third-largest market and second largest trading partner. Like Saudi Arabia, India has been both a consistent and moderate pro-status quo power amenable to simpler paradigms of economic complementarity.

Riyadh finds ties with India uncluttered by extraneous considerations. India is a geo-strategically safe bet for the turbulent Gulf. Riyadh, facing a huge paradigm shift, is most unlikely to wade into supporting Pakistan's adventurism against India. So, while the MJDA may give Islamabad an adrenaline high, Pakistan's quest to match India's rise through military fluster in West Asia is unlikely to succeed.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Approach to delimitation

Neither the votaries of delimitation nor its critics have come up with any convincing arguments or acceptable points. If the purpose of delimitation is to ensure equal population representation in every constituency, it is high time that delimitation is undertaken. But the foremost question is whether this will in any way improve the provision of civic amenities and address other social issues. If the delimitation exercise is merely a ruse and the real objective is to improve electoral prospects, it requires deeper introspection. Unless

political parties come clean about their genuine concerns and spell out the pros and cons, this issue will not be resolved to the satisfaction of the people. Data from previous exercises should come in handy to support the case for delimitation, while the resultant increase in the number of people's representatives could act as a deterrent. This critical issue requires deft handling. **V. Lakshmanan,** Tirupur, Tamil Nadu

Tariffs as a weapon

The U.S. Senate's overwhelming approval of a Bill threatening 100% tariffs on countries continuing to

import Russian oil should concern India deeply. Washington's objective may be to squeeze Russia's war revenues, but using trade as a secondary sanction risks penalising countries pursuing their own energy security. India cannot abruptly replace Russian crude, particularly when supplies through the Strait of Hormuz remain uncertain. At the same time, New Delhi must recognise that continued dependence carries a growing geopolitical cost. India should intensify diplomatic engagement with Washington while diversifying energy sources and markets. Strategic

autonomy now requires both economic prudence and diplomatic agility. **Gopalaswamy J.,** Chennai

Such an exorbitant protectionist measure could engender profound distortions in supply chains, exacerbate inflationary pressures and erode the sanctity of the multilateral trading architecture. India must, therefore, exercise strategic circumspection while safeguarding its economic interests. Diplomatic engagement, market diversification and calibrated reciprocity would be more efficacious than retaliatory brinkmanship. In

an interdependent world, protectionism is ultimately inimical to shared prosperity and sustainable economic growth. **Nagarajamani M.V.,** Hyderabad

Reviving Chennai's rivers

The Tamil Nadu Budget has highlighted the plan on cleaning up the Adyar and Cooum rivers in Chennai. Successive governments have allocated crores of rupees towards cleaning these rivers. Yet, for decades, none of them has made any serious attempt to even begin the project in a meaningful way. What Chennai needs today, however, is not merely

announcements about river restoration, but flood-free neighbourhoods and roads. The TVK government should prioritise completing the pending drainage works and take concrete steps to protect Chennai from flooding during the monsoon season. Restoring the Adyar and Cooum could also spell significant tourism potential for Chennai. Clean and well-maintained riverfronts could add to the city's attractiveness as a tourist destination. **N. Mahadevan,** Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Mediating Telangana's inter-State issues

The cost of unconditional cash transfers

Burden or benefit?

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The  Hind.

12 gunny bags of watches seized

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 10, 1926

The Cauvery floods

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of flight cancellations due to Typhoon Dolphin

1,300 Typhoon Dolphin made landfall in densely populated eastern China on Sunday, meteorological authorities said, after the storm triggered more than 1,000 flight cancellations, evacuations and a top-level alert. AFP

Grievances resolved by Delhi Police received during public hearings

368 The Delhi Police has resolved 368 complaints and grievances received during public hearings held at police stations across the national capital on Saturday, as part of its Thana Divas-Jansunwai initiative. The initiative was launched in June. PTI

Area of safe haven carved out for lions in Gujarat

100 hectares. Stepping up efforts to mitigate human-wildlife conflicts, the Gujarat forest department is establishing a 100-hectare enclosure at the Ambardi Safari Park in Amreli district to house Asiatic lions that have attacked humans, an official said on Sunday. PTI

Subsidy to be provided by Himachal Pradesh govt. for cold storage

70 in per cent. The Himachal Pradesh government will provide a 70% subsidy for establishing 5-metric-tonne cold storages, freeze-dry units and refrigerated vans. The cost has been fixed at ₹15 lakh for a 5 MT cold storage unit, ₹10 lakh for a freeze-dry unit and ₹20 lakh for a refrigerated van. PTI

Estimated annual rise in Taiwan's defence spending for 2027

16 in per cent. Taiwan's cabinet will propose a 16% annual rise in defence spending for 2027 which will for the first time exceed T\$1 trillion (\$31 billion), the official Central News Agency reported on Sunday, as Taipei bolsters its military. REUTERS
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The stakes in India's delimitation debate

What triggers delimitation? How will the 2027 Census affect seat allocation? Can the exercise be completed before 2029? Which States could gain or lose seats? What happens without a constitutional amendment? How will women's reservation be implemented? How can new boundaries affect electoral outcomes?

EXPLAINER

Varghese K. George

The story so far:

The BJP is keen to kick off a fresh delimitation of Lok Sabha constituencies. It is trying to garner a two-thirds majority in Parliament to pass a Constitutional amendment for this purpose. In April 2026, it had moved the amendment but could not pass it. The Centre has not revealed its exact proposals. The proposals that the Centre placed before Parliament in the previous Session were the following:

1) Increase the size of the Lok Sabha up to a maximum of 850 seats; 2) distribute these seats among the States based on the 2011 Census through a fresh, countrywide delimitation of constituencies; and 3) reserve one-third of the total seats for women.

According to the existing Constitutional provisions, a fresh delimitation is possible only after the data of the 2027 Census is published, and reservation for women can be rolled out only along with it.

What happens if there is no Constitutional amendment?

For a fresh delimitation to happen, a Constitutional amendment is not required. A fresh delimitation will be triggered soon after the data of the 2027 census is published. The terms for the next delimitation are already written into the Constitution, principally in Articles 81 and 82. A Constitutional amendment is required only if the existing constitutional provisions relating to delimitation are to be changed.

Articles 81 and 82 mandate that after the data from the first Census conducted after 2026 is published, two things will happen.

The first is a reallocation of the existing strength of the Lok Sabha among the States and Union Territories on the basis of the population recorded in that Census, which would, in this case, be the 2027 Census. The second is the delimitation of individual constituencies within each State.

Therefore, if there is no Constitutional amendment at all, there will be a delimitation exercise that must begin after the data of the 2027 Census is published.

ratio remains as of today.

The 2027 Census is the first time that data gathering has been completely digitalised. Theoretically, it is possible that the delimitation process could be quicker than before. If the exercise is not completed before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, it could continue into the term of the next Lok Sabha and the government.

The last Delimitation Commission was appointed during A. B. Vajpayee's tenure as the Prime Minister, and its work was completed during the first term of the Manmohan Singh government, with a Lok Sabha election in 2004 in between. The same can happen with the next Delimitation Commission.

What will be the mandate of the next Delimitation Commission?

If a fresh delimitation is triggered under the existing provisions of Articles 81 and 82, the following will happen.

At present, the distribution of the 543 Lok Sabha seats among the States is based on the population figures of the 1971 Census. When the benchmark changes from the 1971 population to the population recorded in the first Census after 2026, the seat distribution is likely to change (**Table 1**). Broadly speaking, the southern States are likely to face a reduction in their share of Lok Sabha seats, while the Hindi-speaking States, particularly Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan, are likely to gain seats. The maximum number of Lok Sabha seats allowed by the Constitution is 550. A third of the Lok Sabha seats nationally, and one-third of the seats within each State, will be reserved for women.

So, in the absence of any Constitutional amendment, the following sequence is envisaged: first, the reallocation of Lok Sabha seats among States; second, the delimitation of constituencies within States; and third, the implementation of women's reservation – all tied to the Census 2027.

How is the allocation of seats to each State determined?

Think of India as one large joint family and the States as its constituent family units. Imagine that each individual across the joint family was entitled to one acre of land (**Image 1**). A family with five members got five acres, another with seven members got seven acres, and so on. Each family then divided its share among its members. At that point, everyone got roughly the same share. In political terms, every vote had roughly the same value. But then time passed. Some families grew much faster than others. In the larger families, the same land had to be shared among more people. In the smaller families, fewer people shared the same land. As a result, the value of each person's share began to differ.

That is, in a sense, what has happened to votes in India. In 1967, an MP across most major States represented roughly four to five lakh electors. Today, a MP from Kerala represents about 14 lakh electors, while in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, the figure is around 19 lakh.

This variation is the result of a deliberate decision by all parties, taken on two occasions, in 1976 and 2001, not to punish States that had stabilised their populations. The Constitution gives that leeway. The size of Lok Sabha constituencies is not necessarily based on a national average, which today would be about 18 lakh voters per constituency. Article 81 requires seats to be allocated among States "so far as practicable", on the basis of a national average. This leeway for variation allows for a balance between two principles that can be in tension: federalism, or representation of States, and democracy, or one vote, one value.

And that is the central tension the debate

Image 1

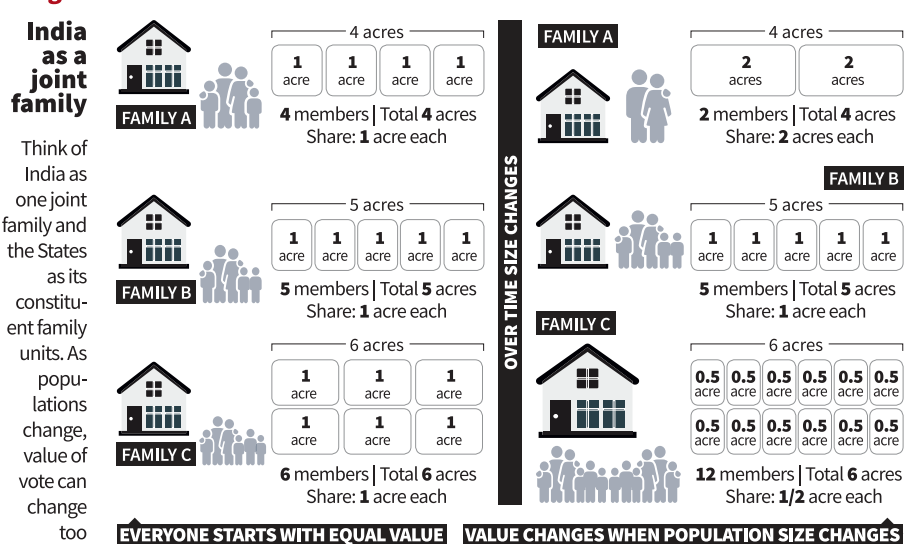
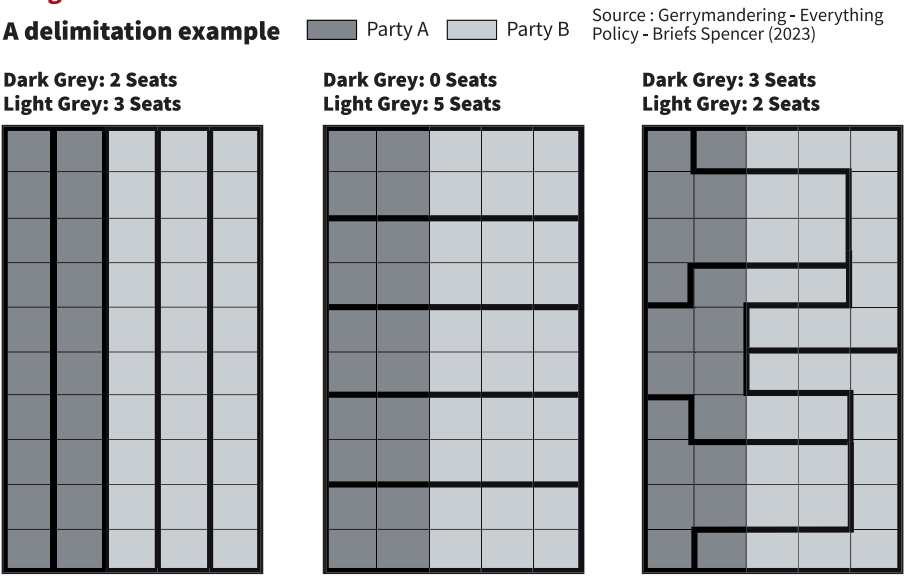


Image 2



Comparison of Lok Sabha seat distribution based on 2024 electors and 2011 population							
State/ Union Territory	Current Seats (543)	Seats*	Seats**	State/ Union Territory	Current Seats (543)	Seats*	Seats**
A.P.	25	23	22	Tamil Nadu	39	35	32
Arunachal Pradesh	2	0	1	Tripura	2	2	2
Assam	14	14	14	U.P.	80	86	90
Bihar	40	43	47	WB	42	42	41
Goa	2	1	1	Chhattisgarh	11	11	11
Gujarat	26	27	27	Jharkhand	14	14	15
Haryana	10	11	11	Uttarakhand	5	5	5
H.P.	4	3	3	Telangana	17	18	16
Karnataka	28	30	27	Andaman & Nicobar Islands	1	0	0
Kerala	20	15	15	Chandigarh	1	0	0
M.P.	29	31	33	Dadra & NH and Daman & Diu	2	0	0
Maharashtra	48	52	50	Delhi	7	8	8
Manipur	2	1	1	Lakshadweep	1	0	0
Meghalaya	2	1	1	Puducherry	1	1	1
Mizoram	1	0	0	J&K	5	5	6
Nagaland	1	1	1	Ladakh	1	0	0
Odisha	21	19	19	Total	543	541	543
Punjab	13	12	12				
Rajasthan	25	30	31				
Sikkim	1	0	0				

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBdOF> on delimitation now needs to resolve.

What is gerrymandering?

When we discuss the democratic principle of One Person, One Vote, One Value, the first requirement is that every Lok Sabha constituency should have roughly the same number of voters. But equal numbers alone do not guarantee equal value for every vote. Why? Because even when constituencies contain the same number of voters, the way those voters are grouped can dramatically affect electoral outcomes.

Consider a simple example (**Image 2**). Imagine there are 50 voters. Party A has 20 supporters and Party B has 30 supporters. There are five constituencies, each with 10 voters and electing one representative.

In the first scenario, voters are distributed fairly across the five constituencies. The result broadly reflects the overall vote share. Party A and Party B win seats broadly in proportion to their

support. In the second scenario, Party A's voters are spread thinly across constituencies. This is called cracking. Although Party A has 40% of all voters, it may not have enough support to win even one constituency. Thus, 40% of voters could end up with no representation at all.

In the third scenario, Party B's voters are heavily concentrated in a few constituencies. This is known as packing. Party B wins those seats with huge margins but ends up wasting votes, allowing Party A to win more seats despite having fewer supporters overall.

The way constituency boundaries are drawn can profoundly shape democratic representation and electoral outcomes.

Extracted from the author's introduction to 'The Delimitation Debate: The Union and its Units,' published by The Hindu. Order the book here:



THE GIST

The 2027 Census is set to trigger a fresh delimitation of Lok Sabha constituencies under Articles 81 and 82, even without a new Constitutional amendment.

The exercise could significantly alter the distribution of Lok Sabha seats, with southern States likely to lose their share and Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan likely to gain.

Redrawing constituency boundaries could also affect electoral outcomes, as the grouping of voters through 'cracking' and 'packing' can influence which parties win seats.



Gearing up: A fresh delimitation will be triggered soon after the data of the 2027 census is published. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Can a fresh delimitation be completed before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections?

May or may not. In the past, delimitation exercises took several years. The last one was set up on 12 July 2002, after the 2001 Census. Its recommendations were implemented in 2008, and the 2009 Lok Sabha elections were held based on newly drawn constituencies.

The last delimitation did not involve a reallocation of seats of individual States; only the existing constituencies within each State were redrawn. The last time Lok Sabha seats were reallocated among States was in 1973, based on the 1971 Census. That

CACHE

A common blueprint for India’s industrial heat electrification

India’s next phase of energy transition must focus on electrifying industrial heat; a coordinated approach involving innovative financing, skilled workers, demonstration projects and cluster-level planning can help scale the transition and strengthen manufacturing competitiveness

Vrinda Gupta
Srinivas Ethiraj

India’s energy transition is already mainstreaming renewable-powered electrification across major demand centres. Electric mobility is replacing internal combustion engines, agriculture is increasingly powered by solar irrigation, and buildings are adopting smarter appliances. The next phase lies in electrifying industrial heat, particularly across India’s MSMEs, to strengthen manufacturing competitiveness, energy security and decarbonisation.

India’s solar photovoltaic revolution reduced solar tariffs by more than 85% over the past decade through a coordinated ecosystem of supportive policies both at the national and state level, innovative financing, competitive vendors and markets, institutional mandates, and sustained private sector investment. Now, scaling industrial heat electrification will require a similar approach. The focus has shifted to how India plans and scales this transition.

No blanket solution

First, facility-level engineering assessments should become the foundation of industrial heat electrification. Most industries have limited visibility of their thermal systems beyond fuel consumption. Steam flow is rarely metered, process temperatures are often unmonitored, and waste heat streams remain unquantified. Without robust engineering assessments, industries risk investing in technologies unsuited to their process requirements. So, engineering assessments should evaluate legacy boiler performance and operating costs, optimise steam systems, identify recoverable waste heat, and where feasible, replace steam with more efficient direct heating before electrification.

Electricity can be used only where it delivers the greatest value. So, process integration tools such as pinch analysis should identify internal heat recovery opportunities before electrification.

Representative facilities can be used to develop standardised process profiles that estimate hourly thermal demand, identify electrifiable heat loads, and inform future electricity demand for utilities and grid operators. Aggregated across industrial clusters, these assessments can support district-level industrial decarbonisation plans tailored to local industrial profiles, renewable resources, and infrastructure readiness. Localised planning recognises that there is no one-size-fits-all solution.

Second, India should adopt a technology-inclusive approach. Industrial processes vary widely in temperature, production schedules, and thermal demand. So a single technology solution is impractical.

Heat pumps are well suited for low- and medium-temperature applications, particularly where waste heat can be recovered. Electric boilers currently offer a practical pathway for steam generation above 200° C. Mechanical vapour recompression systems can recover and reuse process vapour in evaporation-intensive processes. Thermal energy storage solutions can act as thermal buffers by storing surplus heat generated when renewable electricity is

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+48B98m5PQCf84MmQ9>



Powering up: A successful electrification programme hinges on affordable and reliable renewable electricity supply. GETTY IMAGES
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

abundant or recovered from industrial waste heat, and releasing it when process heat is required, improving operational flexibility and reducing peak electricity demand.

Access to capital

Third, a successful electrification programme hinges on affordable and reliable renewable electricity supply. While renewable generation costs have fallen dramatically over the past decade, the delivered cost of renewable electricity for industries remains influenced by network charges, open-access provisions, and other transaction costs.

As India’s commercial and industrial renewable energy market matures, reforms should focus on reducing these costs by streamlining open-access procedures, rationalising banking provisions, reducing transactional complexity, and strengthening grid infrastructure, particularly for electrification projects that replace fossil

The right fit

The following criteria can help identify brownfield units best suited for early deployment of low- and medium-temperature electrification technologies:

Screening criterion	Indicative threshold
Steam generation cost	> ₹2.8 per kg of steam
Steam-to-fuel ratio	< 3 kg steam per kg fuel
Recoverable waste heat	Temperature ≥ 50° C; flow rate ≥ 60 cubic metres per hour
Delivered cost of renewable electricity	< ₹6 per kWh
Boiler service life	> 18 years

fuel-based heating. Renewable electricity planning should be integrated with industrial electrification, enabling industries to align thermal demand with periods of renewable generation.

Fourth, financing models must evolve

alongside technologies. The principal challenge in scaling industrial heat electrification extends beyond technology to reducing engineering and investment risks, particularly for MSMEs with limited access to capital and technical expertise.

Technology leasing, heat-as-a-service, energy service company models, and blended finance can lower the upfront investment and technology risks. Equally important is demand aggregation. Facility-level assessments should feed into cluster-level investment pipelines, allowing industries with similar thermal profiles to aggregate demand, reduce procurement costs, and improve access to low-cost finance.

Demonstration projects

Fifth, India needs skilled workers and implementation capacity tailored to cluster needs. Many industries, particularly MSMEs, face capability and skill gaps that slow technology adoption, reduce efficiency, and limit innovation. Most of the vocational and industry training programmes often focus on routine operations and maintenance. Industrial heat electrification will require an engineering transition at the shop floors rather than a simple equipment replacement exercise. Scaling it requires a workforce of engineers, technicians, and operators with capabilities in process integration, system design, installation, commissioning, operation, and maintenance, and digital automation and control systems.

Sixth, India needs demonstration projects before it needs large-scale mandates. India needs first-of-a-kind demonstration projects across representative sectors, process temperatures, and industrial clusters. This will generate engineering evidence, validate business models, and reduce investment uncertainty. The priority should be to identify the most suitable first-mover facilities.

Based on our analysis in brownfield settings, units that meet these screening criteria are the best candidates for early deployment of low- and medium-temperature (up to 250 °C) electrification technologies (**Table 1**).

Common blueprint

Finally, industrial heat electrification needs a coordinated national framework supported by place-based implementation. It should establish engineering standards, designate institutional responsibility, facilitate demand aggregation, mobilise finance, and support early demonstration projects. Its implementation should be driven through district and cluster-level industrial energy transition plans, allowing each industrial cluster to transition according to its unique thermal profile, local context, electricity market, and renewable energy potential.

India now needs a common blueprint to transform industrial heat electrification into a scalable industrial strategy. Industrial heat offers an opportunity to decarbonise manufacturing, reduce greenhouse gas emissions, and build a more resilient and future-ready industrial economy.

(Vrinda Gupta is associate director, Energy Transition, Vasudha Foundation. Srinivas Ethiraj is assistant manager, Energy Transition, Vasudha Foundation)



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

The rejection punctured his enthusiasm

The proposal was dead on arrival from the very beginning

S. Upendran

“The monsoon is here, finally! The people in our building are celebrating.”
“I, for one, am over the moon. Sujatha is throwing a party this weekend.”
“She told me, but I won’t be able to come. I’m busy Sunday.”
“You’re busy Sunday? You mean, ‘I’m busy on Sunday’, don’t you?”
“We’re both right! In informal contexts, it’s acceptable to say, ‘I’m busy Sunday’, without the ‘on’. Americans do it quite often.”
“I see. How about this example? The children’s school reopens Tuesday.”
“Sounds good. But remember such sentences are okay in informal contexts. But they’ll be frowned upon in writing.”
“Especially if it’s a formal email or letter you’re writing.”
“That’s right! Anyway, whether Sujatha’s party is Sunday or on Sunday, I won’t be able to come. Meeting Gautam Sunday evening.”
“How is he doing? I heard that his partner took over his company.”
“He never expected his partner to do it. His ego was punctured, and he...”
“Does it mean his ego had a flat tyre?”
“In a sense, yes. When someone punctures your ego, what he does is to make you lose or weaken your confidence.”
“That happens whenever I talk to Bala. Every time we have a discussion, he punctures every argument I put forward.”
“It’s not just the argument that you put forward. He punctures everyone’s arguments. By the way, it’s not just arguments that can be punctured. A person’s beliefs, feelings and dreams can also be punctured. For example, Mayank’s love for cricket was punctured when he saw his brother being hit on head by a bouncer.”
“A hit on the head can definitely puncture one’s enthusiasm for the game, I guess. Hemant’s dream of buying a new flat was punctured when the bank turned down his application for a loan.”
“When I learnt that Revathi was a member of the selection committee, my positive mood was punctured.”
“Revathi’s cutting remarks have punctured the ego of many candidates.”
“That’s so true! She can be quite nasty when she’s in a bad mood.”
“Do you think Management will accept the changes she’s recommended?”
“Not a chance! I think the proposal is dead on arrival. It needs...”
“What are you talking about?”
“It means that it is unlikely to be passed. It’s unlikely to get the required number of votes. It will fail.”
“I see.”
“It was first used with patients who died before they could reach the hospital. The doctors declared my grandfather dead on arrival. The expression is often abbreviated to DOA. Over the years, it has acquired a figurative meaning. You normally use it to suggest that something - it could be a plan, and idea, proposal, etc. - that is unlikely to be accepted.”
“I see. If you ask me, the bill that the Speaker has tabled is dead on arrival.”
“The peace plan that we put forward yesterday is dead on arrival.”
“That must have punctured your ego!”
upendrankye@gmail.com

THE DAILY QUIZ

On August 10, 1793, one of the most famous museums in the world, the Louvre, was opened for the public. A quiz on the museum and its works

Joan Sony Cherian

QUESTION 1
The establishment of the museum is closely linked with this paramount event in 1789. Name the event.

QUESTION 2
A steel-and-glass pyramid, known as the Louvre Pyramid, serves as the entrance to the museum. Name the architect who designed it.

QUESTION 3
During the Nazi occupation of France in the Second World War, many treasures of the

museum, including the Mona Lisa, were transported to secret hiding places. Name the director of the museum who was responsible for ensuring the safe transport of these artifacts.

QUESTION 4
The Louvre was once the official residence of French Monarchs. When did it stop becoming the royal seat?

QUESTION 5
Last year, the Louvre was burgled by brazen thieves who entered the museum disguised as construction workers. What did they steal?



Visual Question:
What is this building and where is it located? SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. Why was August 7 chosen as the National Handloom Day? **Ans: To commemorate the ‘Swadeshi Movement’**
2. After whom is the country’s highest recognition for handloom weavers who have demonstrated extraordinary craftsmanship and dedication to the preservation and promotion of India’s weaving traditions named? **Ans: Sant Kabir, who was a weaver**
3. Which State is synonymous with the Wangkhei Phee and Shapee Lanphee weaves? **Ans: Manipur**
4. Name the master weaver of the Gods in Hindu mythology from whom the silk weavers of Kanchipuram consider their descentance. **Ans: Sage Markanda**
5. What is special about Eri silk, locally called Ryndia, from Meghalaya? **Ans: It is ‘Ahimsa’ or ‘Peace’ silk where the yarn is spun after the moth exits the cocoon naturally**
6. Which popular weave from Central India was patronised by Queen Ahilyabai Holkar? **Ans: Maheshwari**
7. Where is Calico Museum of Textiles? **Ans: Ahmedabad**
Visual: Name this social reformer affectionately called ‘Hatkargha Maa’ (Handloom Mother) **Ans: Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay**
Early Birds: Tsewang Chosdon | Saniya Kumari | Abhay Krishan | Prem Raj P. | Devan Monga

Word of the day

Persnickety:
characterised by excessive precision and attention to trivial details

Synonyms: careful, picky, fussy, particular

Usage: *She is persnickety about how her room is arranged.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/persnickety

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ˌpɜːnsɪkəti/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

If your NPS corpus is too small

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

“What’s the point of receiving a pension of just a few hundred rupees a month?” an acquaintance asked me recently. We were discussing the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority’s (PFRDA) revised exit rules for the National Pension System (NPS). It is a fair question. At a certain age, you begin to simplify life. Activities reduce, commitments turn fewer, unnecessary work is quietly dropped and somehow the little glass figurines in the showcase disappear as well! Investments get streamlined, portfolios are consolidated, scattered mutual fund folios merged and the lone fixed deposit in a distant bank is redeemed. The objective is not merely to maximise returns but to make life simpler. For some people, an NPS account now falls into that category. This is not true for everyone. But if you shifted to the new tax regime, no longer receive additional tax deduction for NPS contributions and accumulated only a modest corpus, it may be time to review if continuing the account still serves financial goals. Why discuss NPS in an insurance column? Because the NPS end game is purchase of an annuity viz. a pension



Little use: If the corpus is small, the pension generated is likely to be modest.

product offered by life insurers. And why now? Because the revised PFRDA rules have made it easier for some subscribers to exit.

Changing equation

If the NPS corpus is up to ₹8 lakh, you can withdraw the full amount without purchasing an annuity. Earlier, part of the corpus had to be compulsorily used to buy one. For many investors, that changes the equation. An annuity has its place. It provides an income for life, something few financial products can promise. But if the corpus is small, the pension it generates is likely to be modest. A corpus of about ₹8 lakh may translate into an annual pension of roughly ₹5,000, depending on age and option chosen. Some investors may decide they would rather deploy the money elsewhere.

Large corpus, more choices

If your corpus is larger, you have more choices. You can continue with NPS, defer exit, withdraw a part of the corpus and use the balance to buy an annuity or simply keep the account without making fresh contributions. The right answer depends on overall retirement income not NPS alone.

Advantage of buying annuity

There is another point worth remembering. Buying an annuity via NPS has one important advantage: there is no GST on the purchase. Your entire amount goes towards buying the pension. Outside NPS, GST is payable. Depending on corpus size, this benefit can be meaningful. The new rules are therefore not an invitation to exit NPS. They are an opportunity to rethink it. Retirement planning is not only about accumulating investments. It is also about knowing when to simplify them. If your NPS account has become a small holding that no longer offers tax benefits and adds little to your retirement income, this may be the right time to decide whether it still deserves a place in your portfolio. (The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history.)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

Mutual Fund flows and takeaways for you

Investors are staying invested despite volatility, getting comfortable delegating market-cap allocation decisions to fund managers and warming up to one-stop asset allocation via MAFs

FLOW CHART

Joydeep Sen

Mutual Funds (MFs) come in multiple categories, spanning equity, debt and hybrid structures. Tracking categories receiving more flows than others give us a clue on what a majority of investors are preferring at a point in time. You have to gauge which category is suitable for your risk appetite and time horizon. Two categories have been excluded from this analysis. One is Sectoral/Thematic Funds since the AMFI data for this category is a cumulation of multiple sub-categories from banking to infrastructure to pharma and is not comparable with other single-strategy categories. The other exclusion is Liquid Funds as this is dominated by corporate investors parking treasury money. Our data source for this piece is the AMFI Monthly Note.

Flexi Cap leads flows The category receiving the highest flows from December 2025 to June 2026 is Flexi Cap funds. Gross flows, before redemptions, has been ₹55,225 crore. Here, the fund manager faces no curbs in allocation to large-, mid- or small-cap stocks and is entirely at manager’s discretion. Given the flexibility, strategy varies from one AMC to another. That said, there is a general bias to-

In Flexi-cap funds, the fund manager faces no curbs in allocation to large-, mid- or small-cap stocks and is entirely at the discretion of the fund manager

wards large caps in most such portfolios since they are relatively less volatile vis-a-vis mid- or small-caps, cushioning the fund in times of market stress. The inference is instructive. Though equity market has been somewhat volatile, that investors are continuing to build portfolios is a sign of their growing maturity. It also tells us investors are comfortable with the fund manager handling market-cap allocation decision. That is the value proposition a Flexi Cap fund offers which investors seem to be recognising.

Multi-assets gain The next most popular category in terms of flows over the last seven months is Multi-asset allocation funds or MAFs under which gross flow was ₹45,453 crore. A MAF combines three or more asset classes such as equity, debt, global equity, gold, silver, REITs and InvITs in a single fund structure. Rather than investors buying separate equity, debt and gold funds and then manage the allocation, a single MAF does the

As fewer taxpayers find it worthwhile to stay in the Old Tax Regime to claim this deduction, the flow of fresh money into ELSS funds has naturally tapered off

job. This imparts the benefit of asset allocation in one product and inculcates discipline. When the intended allocation ratio gets altered, for instance if equity rallies and weight in portfolio rises beyond the target, the fund manager books profit in equity and rebalances towards the original ratio. If investors were to attempt this on their own, there would be a tax implication every time they switched funds. MAF Inflows picked up after equity turned volatile after September 2024. The rally in gold prices till February contributed to MAFs positive sentiment.

Mid-, small-cap flows The other two categories seeing buoyant flows over the last seven months are Mid-cap and Small-cap funds. Valuations of mid-cap and small-cap stocks are relatively stretched compared with large caps. The risk level in the categories is relatively higher and investor must have a long investment horizon to ride out the volatility coming with it. The one category consistently losing corpus is

Equity Linked Savings Schemes (ELSS).

ELSS funds lose The primary motivation for investing in ELSS was the tax benefit under Section 80C of the Income Tax Act, now Section 123 of the new Income Tax Act. Given the New Tax Regime is more beneficial for an overwhelming majority of the I-T payers, the Old Tax Regime and the relevance of Section 80C (now Section 123) deductions is steadily losing charm. As fewer taxpayers find it worthwhile to stay in the Old Tax Regime to claim this deduction, the flow of fresh money into ELSS funds has naturally tapered off.

The takeaway Data across categories tells a fairly coherent story. Investors are staying invested despite volatility, increasingly getting comfortable delegating market-cap allocation decisions to fund managers via Flexi Cap funds and warming up to the idea of one-stop asset allocation via MAFs. At the same time, elevated flows into Mid- and Small-cap funds call for caution than imitation. As always, use this as a reference point for what the market at large is doing and then map it against goals, risk appetite and time horizon before deciding what is right for you. Popularity and suitability are not the same. (Joydeep Sen is a corporate trainer (financial markets) and author)

Transfer to core from satellite?

THINKINVESTOR

You can transfer gains from your satellite to a core portfolio but not the other way around; this constraint is very important to protect the excess gains you may have in any of your core portfolios

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Previously in this column, we discussed the benefits of creating and managing a satellite portfolio; you can use the gains from the satellite portfolio to bridge a shortfall in any of core portfolios. What if there is no shortfall and the satellite portfolio is generating handsome gains? Here, we discuss why you should not transfer money from core to satellite portfolio.

Market timing

If you pursue three life goals, you should have three core portfolios. The portfolio with the longest time horizon will be retirement portfolio to accumulate wealth to meet post retirement expenses. When the satellite portfolio is generating handsome gains, you may be tempted to raise trading capital by transferring money from retirement portfolio. The argument could be retirement is far away and you can bridge any shortfall during the last 10 years of working life. There are, however, two factors to be mindful of.

Market timing, skill, luck

One, the satellite portfolio is about market timing involving skill and luck. If you have a period of bad luck, you could lose a huge part of the money transferred from the core to the satellite portfolio. Recovering losses is more difficult than giving-up gains of the same magnitude. For instance, 50% unrealised losses require 100% appreciation in value to recover the loss but 50% unrealised gains requires only 33% dip to wipe-out the gains. Two, if you are tempted to transfer excess returns in any core portfolio to the satellite portfolio, think about this.

Suppose you expect 12% pre-tax return on equity investment in child’s education portfolio. If the investment were to experience 14% return, it would be optimal to take out the excess returns of two percentage points and create a fixed deposit. The deposit can be used as capital when actual return on equity investments in any year is less than 12% during the remaining time horizon for the goal.

Conclusion

You can transfer gains from your satellite to a core portfolio but not the other way around. This constraint is important to protect excess gains you may have in any of your core portfolios. Such gains can be also used as buffer capital to account for inflation risk, as the amount needed to achieve the goal can increase because of inflation. (The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.35	7.40	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.10	7.10	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.00	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.00	8.00	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	8.00	6.00	7.50	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	8.10	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.80	7.25	7.25	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	8.10	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.50	6.25	6.50	6.50
Bandhan Bank	7.45	7.00	7.25	5.85
City Union Bank	7.25	6.65	6.50	6.55
CSB Bank	7.35	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.85	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.50	6.90	7.00	7.50
Federal Bank	6.70	6.25	6.40	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.25	6.50	7.25	6.75
IndusInd Bank	7.00	6.75	7.00	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Public Sector Banks				
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.05	6.55	6.80	6.85
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	7.00	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.80	6.35	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.30	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.80	6.25	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.25	6.80	6.70	6.70
YES Bank	7.25	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.75	6.25	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.85	6.50	6.70	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.40	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.70	6.10	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.65	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.35
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.85	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.55	6.20	6.10	6.00

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60
Punjab National Bank	7.30-9.30	7.25-9.20	7.25-9.20
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.00-9.90	7.00-9.90	7.00-9.90
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.35-10.75	7.35-10.75	7.35-10.75
Indian Overseas Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
ICICI Bank	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.48-11.80	7.48-11.80	7.48-11.80
Federal Bank	8.35 - 10.25	7.35 - 10.25	7.35 - 9.25

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank			
Bandhan Bank	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
RBL Bank	8.55 - 13.52	8.55 - 13.52	8.55 - 13.52
CSB Bank	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
HDFC Bank	8.30 #	8.30 #	8.30 #
City Union Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Tata Capital	7.25 #	7.25 #	7.25 #
PNB Housing Finance	8.00 #	8.00 #	8.00 #
GIC Housing Finance	7.75-14.50	7.75-14.50	7.50-9.95
SMFG India Home Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
Sammaan Capital	9.25 #	9.25 #	9.25 #
Aditya Birla Capital	8.75 #	8.75 #	8.75 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
Godrej Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
*Extra interest rate concession of 0.05% to borrowers opting for insurance policy. Rates as on August 5 #onwards Source:Paisabazaar.com			

WASHINGTON
Former U.S. President Joe Biden's cancer has spread further, says son



Former U.S. President Joe Biden's prostate cancer has metastasised further, according to his son Hunter Biden, who shared the update in an interview with the BBC. Mr. Hunter said his father's disease has spread despite the treatment. "It's very painful, and it's very debilitating in many respects, but he's still out there," he said. AFP

ISLAMABAD
Mecca pact with Saudi Arabia and Turkiye 'purely defensive': Pakistan



Pakistan's Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar said on Sunday the landmark Mecca Joint Defence Agreement his country signed with Saudi Arabia and Turkiye was not directed against any country and remained open to other nations in the region. In a post on X, Mr. Dar said the agreement was "purely defensive in nature". AP

DAMASCUS
Syria reaches understanding with Moscow on future of Russian bases



Syria and Russia have reached a memorandum of understanding on the fate of Russian bases at Tartous and Hmeimim after 18 months of talks. Syria's Foreign Ministry said on Sunday Damascus would take over management of civilian facilities, including Hmeimim airport and the commercial berth at Tartous port. REUTERS

BANGKOK
Thai teen school shooter watched violent content online, police say



The Thai teen behind a deadly school shooting on August 7 outside Bangkok had an air gun confiscated by a teacher last year and had watched violent content online, police said on Sunday, as the government promised new safety protocols for schools. Eight people died in Thailand's worst mass shooting since 2022. REUTERS

Trump says U.S. going 'low key' as Tehran firm on Hormuz demands

U.S. President says his administration is only 'semi-negotiating', will wait and watch economic pressure mount on Iran; Hormuz deal with Oman in final stages, says Araghchi, reiterates U.S. must fulfil conditions for reopening of key waterway

Reuters
DUBAI/WASHINGTON/CAIRO

U.S. President Donald Trump signalled on Sunday he is prepared to let economic pressure mount against Iran, apparently backing away from ordering more military strikes even as Tehran issues tough demands.

"We are low-keying it," Mr. Trump said, according to the news outlet Axios.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said on Sunday that a deal with Oman defining new shipping lanes in the Strait of Hormuz was in its "final stages" but repeated comments made on Saturday



Silent watch: A banner with an image of Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei at Valiasr Square in Tehran on Saturday. AFP

that it would not reopen the waterway unless other conditions were met. He also denied on Sunday that Iran was negotiating with the U.S., saying they were merely "exchanging messages" via intermediaries.

"We are only semi-negotiating with them. We are just watching Iran with its huge inflation and the fact they have no money," Mr. Trump was quoted as saying.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards also reiterated on Sunday that they would not reopen the strait until demands were met, including U.S. compensation for war damage. The strategy was to maintain the closure "until the enemy accepts all our conditions... the strait is now actually a theatre of war for us and not just a waterway", the Guards said.

The conditions listed include ending U.S. threats against Iran, stopping aggression against Iran and its Lebanese, Palestinian, Yemeni and Iraqi allies, lifting a blockade and sanctions on Iran and freeing Iranian assets.

Rare meet

Iranian state media said on Sunday that President Masoud Pezeshkian had met Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei in late July and a paramilitary leader has promised new footage of the Supreme Leader, who has not been seen in public since being reportedly injured in the air strike that killed his father and predecessor on February 28, the first day of U.S.-Israeli air strikes on Iran.

(With inputs from AFP)

7 killed as Russia, Ukraine exchange overnight strikes

Associated Press
KYIV

Russia and Ukraine exchanged strikes overnight that killed civilians and injured many others on both sides, local authorities reported on Sunday.

Ukrainian drones killed five people and injured two dozen others, including a 4-year-old boy, in Russia's border region of Belgorod, according to the regional administration.

In Kharkiv, Ukraine's second-largest city, Russian missiles struck a high-rise apartment block in the Saltivskiy district, killing two people and injuring 13, according to regional head Oleh Syniehubov.

Eight people were injured in Ukraine's Black Sea port of Odesa after "dozens of missiles and



Aftermath of attack: Burned cars at the site of a Russian air raid in Odesa, Ukraine on Sunday. AFP

drones" struck the city, according to local officials.

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the seaport had been damaged by the strike.

Large-scale Russian missile strikes on Ukrainian cities have become almost routine in recent weeks, with Moscow exploiting Ukraine's critical shortage of interceptors for the U.S.-

made Patriot systems – the sole air defence weapon in its arsenal able to shoot down ballistic missiles.

Meanwhile, Kyiv has kept up long-range drone strikes against Russian energy infrastructure, as well as the country's largest online retailer, Wildberries, and other targets deep inside Russia, sparking a fuel crisis.

Bombings mark first day in office for new Colombian President

Agence France-Presse
BOGOTA

Two bombing attacks in different parts of Colombia on Saturday marked the first day in office for new President Abelardo de la Espriella, leaving at least one police officer dead and several wounded.

The tough-talking hard-right leader campaigned on confronting "narcoterrorism without truce" and ending peace talks with armed groups following his inauguration on Friday in the city of Cali.

His inauguration comes during the worst wave of violence the country has experienced in the last decade.

Colombia's Army said FARC guerilla dissidents used explosives to destroy a highway tollbooth near Cali in the early hours of Saturday.

Mr. De la Espriella condemned the bombing, saying "attacking the country's infrastructure is attacking progress" in an X post. "To those responsible, I send a clear message: there will be no refuge, no leniency and no impunity," he added.

About 1,000 kilometres away, in the northern department of Cesar, an officer was killed in another bombing when an explosive-equipped drone struck a police station, officials said.

Wildfire in western Canada forces over 20,000 evacuations

Agence France-Presse
VICTORIA

Canadian officials declared a state of emergency on Saturday after a fast-moving wildfire in the western province of British Columbia forced the overnight evacuation of more than 20,000 people.

Winds fanned the Bald Range wildfire to grow rapidly late on Friday, pushing flames into the Summerland area and affecting communities throughout the surrounding valleys.

"We know there have been significant losses of property. We also know that some people became trapped as conditions changed quickly," British

Columbia Premier David Eby said in a statement.

"Air evacuations are under way for people who remain isolated behind the fire perimeter," Mr. Eby said.

The Bald Range fire covered an estimated area of 25,552 acres as of early Sunday, according to the BC Wildfire Service website. It reported a total of 102 active wildfires in the province as of early Sunday, with nearly half of them deemed out of control.

Kelly Greene, the province's Minister of Emergency Management and Climate Readiness, declared a state of emergency.

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Pentagon pushes for faster weapons production amid stockpile shortage

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

The Pentagon is pressing the U.S. defence industry to accelerate production of weapons to help replenish its diminished stockpile of munitions, including those depleted in the ongoing war with Iran.

Pentagon spokesman Sean Parnell said in a statement on Saturday that the department was actively focused on boosting munitions acquisitions to provide "the weapons our warfighters need at the pace the threat demands." He confirmed department efforts in the last week to significantly speed the process but insisted it was part of a broader modernisation effort that predated the five-month-old conflict.

Deputy Defence Secretary Steve Feinberg wrote to industry leaders on Wednesday, giving them no more than 21 days to



THAAD interceptor inventories fell from 452 before the Iran war to roughly 232-262 in April, according to U.S. think tank CSIS. REUTERS

submit plans to "drive significantly faster, more aggressive delivery schedules and/or increased production for critical capabilities," according to a memo obtained by *The Washington Post*.

"Years-long development cycles are not acceptable," Mr. Feinberg wrote. "We must dramatically accelerate our program schedules and expand our production capacity now."

The memo comes as recent fighting with Iran used up more of the U.S. military's already diminished stockpiles of advanced missile interceptors, potentially putting American troops at more risk if hostilities resume, according to a new analysis.

However, President Donald Trump has bristled over public reports of a munitions shortage, posting on Truth Social on Thursday that the U.S. has "massive amounts."

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BEST IN CLASS

‘Kohli an exemplary professional, tries to meet his standards always’



AFP

There is no doubt that Virat Kohli is an exemplary professional. The standards he sets for himself... he tries and goes out every time he plays to meet those standards. And that is why he is a great role model. I think a lot of youngsters or players want to emulate him — V.V.S Laxman, head of BCCI's Centre of Excellence (CoE).

ALL IS WELL

‘Kuldeep took a break to assess body, not due to fitness concern’



FILE PHOTO: PTI

Kuldeep Yadav didn't bowl in the second innings of the warm-up game against Sri Lanka Cricket XI as he wanted to assess his body after a heavy workload, India's spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule said. "He had a very good outing and just wanted to take a break," Bahutule said.

METICULOUS

Gill takes his preparation very seriously, says Bahutule



X@BCCI

India's spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule praised Shubman Gill's meticulous preparation, saying he was preparing specifically for the threat posed by Sri Lanka's spinners. "Gill takes his preparation very seriously. He understands whatever is the demand for that particular series... his preparation is done accordingly," he said.

NO-SHOW

World No. 1 Sinner withdraws from Cincinnati Open with knee injury



AFP

World No. 1 Jannik Sinner will be absent from the Cincinnati Open due to a right knee injury, the tournament announced on Sunday. "After consulting with my doctors and my team, I have to announce that I need to withdraw from the Masters 1000 tournament in Cincinnati," the Italian said in a statement.

Ashmita stuns Han to bag her maiden BWF Tour title

Coach Park, who has now seen two of his wards win Super 300 tournaments in successive weeks, believes the Assam girl always had the tools to succeed, wants her to be more consistent



On a high: Ashmita with Park after her memorable triumph.

BADMINTON

Press Trust of India
ASAN (KOREA)

Ashmita Chaliha produced a gritty show to secure her maiden BWF World tour title with a fighting win over fourth seed Han Qian Xi of China in the women's singles final of the Korea Masters Super 300 badminton tournament on Sunday.

Slow start

The 26-year-old from Assam, who had suffered a career-threatening knee injury two years back in Korea, overcame a slow start and a testing decider to complete a memorable victory, recovering from the loss of the opening game to stun world No. 35 Han 14-21, 21-14, 21-14 in the summit clash that lasted 53 minutes.

"I feel really great and unbelievable. But then I am trying to digest it. Now,

"In the first game, it was a little bit tricky because of the drift conditions, so I



I am hungry for more," said Ashmita, who trains under Park Tae-Sang at the National Centre of Excellence in Guwahati.

was not able to manage it... But in the second, the other side was more comfortable and there was less drift, so I was able to control it,"

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MmQ9>
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6Bd0F>

Sarfaraz replaces the injured Sai Sudharsan in Test squad

CRICKET

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Sarfaraz Khan has returned to India's Test squad after 20 months, with the Mumbai batter replacing the injured B. Sai Sudharsan for the two-Test series against Sri Lanka.

The Hindu understands that the selection committee, in consultation with the team management, picked Sarfaraz after Sai Sudharsan did not recover in time from a right big-toe stress injury.

The BCCI announced Sarfaraz's inclusion on Sunday.

He is expected to link up with the Indian team in Co-



Comeback: Sarfaraz last played for India in November 2024.
FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

lombo before the side travels to Galle on Tuesday.

The 28-year-old had emerged as a primary contender alongside Shaik Rasheed and Rituraj Gaikwad. Rasheed, who has

been knocking on the selectors' door after a prolific domestic run, was considered for his ability to bat in the top-order while Rituraj's experience and First Class record kept him in

the conversation.

Sarfaraz's selection marks the return of a batter whose Test career had appeared to stall after his promising debut in 2024.

He was conspicuously left out of India's squad after not getting an opportunity during the 2024-25 Border-Gavaskar Trophy. All of his six Test appearances came in 2024.

The Mumbai batter has continued to remain a top performer in domestic cricket, keeping himself in the selection frame despite the long hiatus at the international level.

The vacancy at No. 3, created by Sai Sudharsan's absence, may give Sarfaraz a chance to revive his Test career that began with considerable promise.

There is brilliant coordination between CoE and Indian team management, insists Laxman



Straight bat: Laxman, seen here with Saikia and BCCI president Mithun Manhas, defended CoE's injury-management methods. SUDHAKARA JAIN

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

With Indian cricket in the throes of an injury crisis, the latest being Jasprit Bumrah and B. Sai Sudharsan's absence from the upcoming tour to Sri Lanka, V.V.S. Laxman, head of BCCI's Centre of Excellence (CoE), defended the institution's injury-management methods and recovery protocols.

"We don't like to use the word blame, because when you do, you're [trying to] find a scapegoat," Laxman told reporters at the CoE premises on Sunday. "There's brilliant coordination between the CoE, the team management and the SSM (Sports Science & Medicine) staff."

There has been a worrying trend of players being declared fit only to pick up a new injury within a short period of time. Laxman stressed that this was not a cause for concern even as he clarified that the "CoE was not a rehab centre" and that it had a "bigger

mandate".

"When someone is playing at the elite level, you're supposed to give more than 100%," Laxman said. "Injuries are bound to happen. If you're thinking about not getting injured, you're not playing to the best of your ability. Monitoring is very, very critical, and I've got no doubt that Adrian Le Roux (S&C coach, Indian team) and others are doing that," the 51-year-old added.

Both Bumrah and Sai Sudharsan were named conditionally in the squad for the two Tests against Sri Lanka before failing to obtain fitness clearances. Asked if it would be prudent to avoid players who are still undergoing rehabilitation, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia replied in the negative.

"We have our selection meetings at least three to four weeks before the team departs," Saikia said. "We don't reject because by the time the player will have to travel or play, he may be totally fit. It's a human bo-

dy, not a machine. It may take 14 days or 28 days."

The CoE has been without a Head of Sports Science since Nitin Patel's exit in March 2025. Saikia attributed this to an "acute shortage of right candidates" and Laxman stated that there will be no seemingly haste in the appointment process, for quality was paramount.

Andrew Leipus, who had had successful tenures with the Indian National team and the erstwhile National Cricket Academy, was the BCCI's first choice to replace Nitin, but he pulled out.

"Andrew had almost agreed but then backed out," Laxman said.

"The next interview process was extensive, and the first candidate was from Australia, but he did not join. The second and third candidates are already working at the CoE. It is our responsibility to up-skill them while we identify someone of that stature, experience and knowledge."

More Duleep Trophy games to be telecast live: Saikia

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

This time last year, when the 2025-26 Duleep Trophy was held at the BCCI's sprawling Centre of Excellence (CoE) in the city outskirts, supporters were a disappointed lot.

The first-round matches of the domestic cricket season-opener were not broadcast on television and the whole tournament was held behind closed doors. However, in glad tidings for the fans, the 2026-27 edition, which begins on August 23 at the CoE, will see an increased share of matches on television.

And the BCCI even said that it would explore the option of holding at least the final at a proper stadium which can seat an audience. "There are some government restrictions to how we use this land and because of that, we cannot have crowds in this campus," BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia said on Sunday while answering a question from The Hindu.

"But this year, we have increased the number of matches to be telecast. That way, we are giving fans the chance to watch their favourite players and teams. We definitely appreciate your suggestion to see whether the final can be hosted in a stadium. We still have time and we'll look into that aspect."



We definitely appreciate your suggestion to see whether the final can be hosted in a stadium

Jaiswal and Gill find form as India canters to a victory in warm-up game

Press Trust of India
COLOMBO

Yashasvi Jaiswal and Shubman Gill scored useful runs at the top of the order before Mohammed Siraj's late blitz helped India beat Sri Lanka Cricket XI by six wickets in their three-day warm-up game here on Sunday.

Chasing 207 for victory, India achieved the target in 45 overs, finishing on 214 for four with Siraj smashing 32 off just 15 balls, including three successive sixes, to bring the game to an emphatic finish.

Jaiswal made a quickfire 61 off 46 balls. He and Gill put on 105 for the opening



Back in the groove: Gill and Jaiswal provided a flying start. X@BCCI

wicket to give India a flying start to their chase. Jaiswal retired after reaching his half-century.

Gill made a useful 44 be-

fore being dismissed by spinner Keshara Nuwantha.

Dhruv Jurel chipped in with 17, while Rishabh Pant

made a patient 28 before India was briefly reduced to 155 for three.

But the target was never in serious danger, with the lower-order completing the chase in the final session. Siraj then provided the fireworks, hitting three consecutive sixes to finish the game in style.

Earlier, Sri Lanka Cricket XI declared their second innings at 200 for six in 45 overs, leaving India a target of 207.

The scores: Sri Lanka Cricket XI 363/8 decl. and 200/6 decl. (Nishan Fernando 63, Nipun Dhanjaya 46) lost to India 357/6 decl. and 214/4 in 45 overs (Jaiswal 61 (retired hurt), Gill 44, Siraj 35 n.o.)

INBRIEF



Sanya Vats finishes runner-up in Ballarat Open squash

Sanya Vats finished runner-up at the Ballarat Open squash, a \$3000 PSA Challenger event in Victoria, Australia on Sunday. The second seed Indian went down 6-11, 8-11, 6-11 to top seed and local favourite Sarah Cardwell in the women's final. The Delhi girl earlier beat South Korean Ain Jun 11-5, 11-8, 11-4 in the semifinals after defeating another South Korean Sunghee Oh 6-11, 11-9, 12-10, 11-4 in the quarterfinals.



Raul Fernandez speeds to glory in British MotoGP

Aprilia-Trackhouse's Spanish rider Raul Fernandez won the British MotoGP Grand Prix on Sunday, claiming just the second race victory of his career. Championship leader Jorge Martin started on pole but was outpaced from the flag by his 25-year-old compatriot. Martin finished second with Italian Marco Bezzecchi rounding off the podium.



Modi meets CWG medallists, lauds their performances

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday met members of the Indian contingent that returned with medals from the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. Interacting with the athletes, Modi said: “Jo khelega, woh khilega. Always cheer for Bharat.” India enjoyed a strong campaign, finishing with 39 medals, including 13 gold. Modi shared a short video clip of his interaction with the medallists on social media, praising the athletes for making the country proud.

Mason Mount injured in friendly against PSG

Manchester United managed a creditable 1-1 draw with European champion Paris Saint-Germain in a Gothenburg friendly on Saturday but the result was overshadowed by an injury to Mason Mount. Mount appeared to suffer a foot injury in Sweden and, following discussions with coaches on the touchline, left the field to be replaced by Tyler Fletcher.

LIVE TELECAST

▼

Ireland vs Afghanistan: Third ODI, FanCode, 3.15 p.m.

Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 4 & 7 p.m.

TNPPL: Sony Sports Ten 4 Tamil & TNPL Official YouTube channel (youtube@tamilnadupremierleague.com), 7.30 p.m.

N R I Triple Power obliges in the feature

RACING

Hyderabad: Trainer D. Netto's filly N R I Triple Power, ridden by Shivam, claimed the Telangana And Andhra Sub Area Trophy, the main event of Sunday's (Aug. 9) races.

The winner is owned by Mr. Ravinder Reddy Male. Trainer: L.V.R. Deshmukh and jockey P. Ajeth Kumar scored a treble each.

1. SULTAN PHEROZE PLATE (DIV. I) (1,100M): MATERIALITY (P. Ajeth Kumar) 1, Ashwa Jaffna (Gaurav) 2, Gacchanmanasvin (Md. Ismail) 3 and Miri (Mohit) 4. Not run: Northern Sky. 3/4, 1-1/2 and 1-1/4. Im, 7.55s. ₹32 (w), 14, 21 and 11 (p). SHP: 65, THP: 44, FP: 261, Q: 192, Tanala: 581. Favourite: Gacchanmanasvin.

Owner: Mr. Kersi H. Vachha. Trainer: L.V.R. Deshmukh.

4. FAIRWAY PLATE (1,600M): QUINTESSENTIAL (P. Ajeth Kumar) 1, American Gangster (Kuldeep Sr.) 2, Beech Wood

TRAU weathers Indian Navy barrage to register a consolation victory

Afridi scores twice to eke out the win as the loser peppers the rival goal with 26 attempts; both sides crash out of the tournament

DURAND CUP

Sports Bureau

Afridi Buyamayum scored twice as TRAU FC beat Indian Navy 2-1 in its final Group 'D' match of the Durand Cup at the Khuman Lampak Stadium in Imphal on Sunday.

Even as Navy dominated the proceedings and kept TRAU under pressure with 26 attempts on goal, the local outfit fought with grit, thanks to the inspired performance of its goalkeeper Tajuddin, to gather three

points. It finished its group engagements with four points at the second spot, while Navy managed three points to be third.

Raengdai advances

Both sides exited from the tournament, while debutant group-topper FC Raengdai moved into the last-eight.

Navy exerted pressure from the start, while TRAU defended solidly.

Afridi Buyamayum unleashed a stunning right-footer from outside the box to draw first blood in the 16th minute against the run of play.

Navy's aggression, including 12 attempts out of which six were on target, in the first half did not produce the desired result.

However, it levelled the scores within seconds of resumption. Khullakpam Zahir Khan capitalised on a defensive lapse to slot the ball in. TRAU withstood the pressure to restore its lead through a counter-attack as Afridi completed his brace in the 60th minute.

The result: At Imphal: Group D: TRAU FC 2 (Afridi Buyamayum 16, 60) bt Indian Navy 1 (Khullakpam Zahir Khan 46).



Hero of the day: Afridi celebrates after scoring one of his two goals. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Meghwal lands high jump silver; Shahnnavaz wins long jump bronze

ATHLETICS

Press Trust of India EUGENE

Basant Kumar Meghwal became the first Indian to win the high jump silver medal at the World Athletics U20 Championships, while Shahnnavaz Khan added the long jump bronze.

The 19-year-old Meghwal from Anupgarh, a border town in Rajasthan's Sri Ganganagar district, cleared a personal-best of 2.21m to win silver.

Algeria's Younes Ayachi



Meghwal with coach Sahana. X@AFIINDIA

won the gold, while Great Britain's Otis Poole took the bronze. All three medallists cleared only 2.21m but failed to sail over 2.24m. The positions were

decided on countback.

Ayachi cleared 2.21m in his first jump, while Meghwal and Poole did the same in their second and third attempts respectively.



Shahnnavaz. X@AFIINDIA

Shahnnavaz clinched the long jump bronze with a best effort of 7.84m. The 18-year-old produced his best jump in his third attempt, with his series reading 7.67m, 7.72m, 7.84m, 7.52m, 7.83m and 5.37m.

R.C. Jithin Arjunan was the other Indian in the final, finishing eighth with a best jump of 7.59m that he achieved in his first and fourth attempts. Italy's Daniele Inzoli won the gold medal with a jump of 7.97m, while Australia's Mason McGroder took silver with a personal best of 7.96m.

FIFA warns of effort to undermine Infantino

Reuters ZURICH

FIFA has warned against what it called a “concerted and ongoing effort” to undermine president Gianni Infantino, saying attempts to challenge his leadership must follow the governing body's statutes and democratic procedures.

The statement came amid an increasingly bitter stand-off over Infantino's leadership following the collapse of his proposal to raise about \$4.2 billion by selling a stake in the commercial rights of the World Cup and other tournaments.

The plan triggered criticism from UEFA, national associations and senior FIFA officials, led to calls for Infantino to resign and prompted a crisis meeting in Morocco at which FIFA's leadership reaffirmed its support for the president.

FIFA, however, did not identify those it said were seeking to undermine Infantino or specify which reports or allegations it was referring to. “Those who do not have the support of FIFA's Member Associations should not seek to achieve through allegation, insinuation or misinformation what they cannot achieve through FIFA's established democratic processes.” It said recent reports had included “unsubstantiated assertions and demonstrably false claims” concerning FIFA and its president.

Sarthak steers Strikers home; Kings chase down 221

DPL

Sports Bureau NEW DELHI

Sarthak Ranjan led the way with a knock of 65 as North Delhi Strikers defeated New Delhi Tigers by seven wickets in the Delhi Premier League at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Sunday.

Having chosen to bowl in the afternoon clash, Strikers were in the driving seat after restricting Tigers to 161 for eight in 20 overs.

Vikas Dixit snared three scalps while Akhil Chaudhary, Ajay Yadav, Arjun Rappria and Mayank Dagar claimed a wicket each.

For Tigers, Hrithik Shokeen, who came in at No. 7, was the top-scorer with an unbeaten 35 off 25 deliveries.

Strikers took control of the chase through an opening stand of 102 between Sarthak and Vaibhav Kandpal. While Sarthak's knock



Great start: Sarthak, left, and Kandpal stitched together an opening partnership of 102. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

consumed just 43 deliveries, Kandpal was willing to play anchor and compile 41 off 36 balls. The target was reached in 19.1 overs.

In the other match, Yugal Saini's 91 helped Central Delhi Kings post a four-wicket win over South Delhi Superstarz.

With Kings set a target of 221, Saini's knock was the difference as his outfit reached home with two balls to spare.

The scores:

New Delhi Tigers 161/8 in 20 overs (Atulya Pandey 32, Hrithik Shokeen 35 n.o., Vikas Dixit 3/28) lost to North Delhi Strikers 165/3 in 19.1 overs (Sarthak Ranjan 65, Vaibhav Kandpal 41, Revant Rakyana 2/26).

South Delhi Superstarz 220/6 in 20 overs (Sanat Sangwan 38, Ayush Badoni 44, Tejasvi Dahiya 69, Money Grewal 2/26, Gavnish Khurana 2/40) lost to Central Delhi Kings 222/6 in 19.4 overs (Yugal Saini 91, Keshav Dabas 39, Rishabh Sharma 2/38, Anshuman Hooda 3/33).



Infantino. AFP

Exclusive Black tipped to deliver in the chief event

HYDERABAD: The five-year-old gelding Exclusive Black may score over his rivals in the upper division of the P.G. Reddy Memorial Trophy, the chief event of Monday's (Aug. 10) races.

1. P.G. REDDY MEMORIAL TROPHY (DIV. III) (1,200m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 1.35 p.m.: 1. Glorious Power (I) Neeraj 61, 2. Torchbearer (6) P. Ajeth K 60, 3. Victoria Doreasani (5) Akshay K 59.5, 4. Rival (3) Ajay K 58, 5. Blue Pantheress (4) Rafique Sk. 54.5, 6. Clefairy (8) A.A. Vikrant 54, 7. Coming Home (2) B.R. Kumar 55.5, 8. Juremento (7) Surya Prakash 50.5.

1. VICTORIA DORESAANI, 2. CLEFAIRY, 3. GLORIOUS POWER

2. ROYAL REVIVE PLATE (1,400m), (Terms) Maiden, 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 2:10: 1. Concordia (5) B.R. Kumar 56, 2. Toshiro (10) Neeraj 56, 3. Wesethesamesun (2) Rafique Sk. 56, 4. Aakarshaka (7) Md. Ismail 54.5, 5. Bayone (3) Kuldeep Sr. 54.5, 6. Digital

Empress (4) Akshay K 54.5, 7. Evan Sville (8) P. Sai K 54.5, 8. Khamagani (11) Gaurav 54.5, 9. Love All (6) R.S. Jodha 54.5, 10. Ruby Tuesday (9) Arjun 54.5 and 11. She's A Bomb (1) Shivam 54.5.

1. DIGITAL EMPRESS, 2. TOSHIRO, 3. SHE'S A BOMB

3. ADLER PLATE (DIV. II) (1,200m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 2:45: 1. Daring Spirit (6) Trevor 60.5, 2. Normui (3) D.S. Deora 60.5, 3. Basilica (1) Akshay K 60, 4. Inderdhanush (4) A.A. Vikrant 58.5, 5. La Quinta (9) Ajay K 57.5, 6. Dream To Fly (5) G. Naresh 57, 7. Ilene (7) B.R. Kumar 55.5, 8. Sadiya (11) P. Ajeth K 54.5, 9. Bold Indian (2) B. Nikhil 52, 10. Moonlite Rose (8) Surya Prakash 51 and 11. Sugriva (10) Arjun 50.

1. DARING SPIRIT, 2. LA QUINTA, 3. ILENE

4. DEVARAKONDA TROPHY (DIV. II) (1,100m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 3:20: 1. Sweet Dancer (4) P. Ajeth K 61, 2.

EDUCATIONPLUS

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H. Kalpana Rao

Often, when I am introduced as a professor of English, the immediate response is “Oh, I need to be careful when I speak to you in English.” Such comments point to a widespread confusion between language proficiency and the study of literature. This is a misconception that needs clarification.

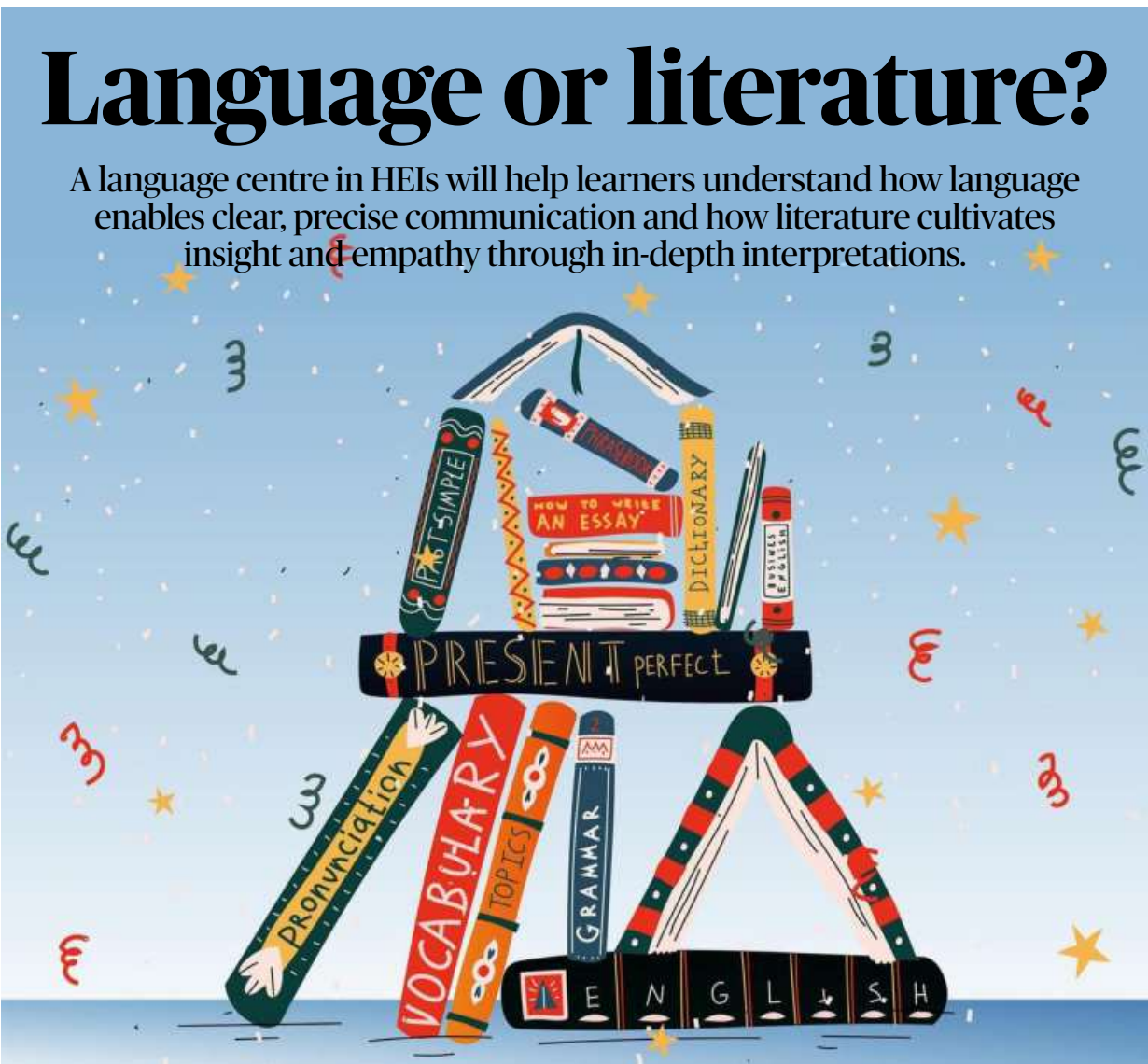
Literature is more content-driven and deals with ideas and experiences and communicates to the reader through an emotional quotient. On the other hand, language is more about the structural aspects, such as understanding grammar, vocabulary, and syntax, and about knowing the underlying structure.

Language training

An important need in higher education today is training in language. This is not to say that literature students are unable to use language.

They do but in a different way. They can analyse and deconstruct plots, stories, and narratives, explore cultural nuances, recognise discrimination, ponder social and political backdrops, and identify the plural meanings that a text offers. Yet, they are unable to draft an essay with the nuanced perspective by which they read a text.

We need to, therefore, find a methodology to improve this. One solution is to set up a language centre that can provide training in English language skills and help scholars and students in academic writing. It is not just literature students



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

who lack the skills necessary to author academic articles.

Students and scholars in the sciences and other fields also find it difficult to communicate their research ideas clearly. This lack of language proficiency also has implications for employability, as students and scholars struggle to write clear resumes, articulate confidently in interviews, and communicate well in professional settings.

In the case of researchers, inadequate language skills limit their ability to produce well-structured dissertations or critically engaged conference papers. Over time, these issues also erode confidence and make students hesitate to participate boldly and positively in academic forums.

Improved presentation

Another lacuna lies in presentation skills. Too often,

scholars, including faculty members, prepare dull slides and speak without preparation, leading to frequent miscommunication and a sense of boredom among listeners. Therefore, a language centre may help by providing support to prepare strong, attractive slides and offering training in seminar presentations and speaking coherently. Additionally, it could also offer structured modules in grammar, vocabulary building, academic writing, and critical reading, along with workshops on citation practices, editing skills and communication.

Such a centre might also collaborate with different departments by designing specific writing sessions such as scientific writing for science students, report writing for social sciences, and research papers for humanities. The centre could be staffed by

English language tutors who combine strong language skills with patience and a supportive approach to learners. Many universities abroad run such writing centres and communication labs that function as academic support hubs offering consultations and skill sustenance across the university.

It is significant that higher education institutions recognise that language is not merely a medium of in-

struction but a tool for thinking, shaping how students organise ideas, construct arguments and engage intellectually at a global level. This does not mean that literature is not necessary. On the other hand, literature nurtures critical consciousness by providing readers to analyse varied perspectives, recognise power structures, and explore the complexities of human experience. Higher educa-

tion needs both these dimensions to exist side by side so that learners understand how language enables clear, precise communication and how literature cultivates insight and empathy through in-depth interpretations.

The writer is a former professor of English at Pondicherry University and now volunteers as the editor for the literary section of the online journal, Muse India. Email: hkalp.eng@pondiuni.ac.in

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Pant — an enigma at the crossroads

Having been replaced as India's Test vice-captain, he can focus on his primary disciplines without having to attend lengthy team discussions or the distraction of being pulled in different directions; the team needs the most potent version of the player to come to the fore

R. Kaushik

When we talk one-format India internationals in the current milieu, almost all the focus is on India's two immediate all-format past skippers. Since May 2025, when they bid adieu to Test cricket within weeks of each other, Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli play for the country only in One-Day Internationals, having already announced their retirement from T20Is at the conclusion of a triumphant World T20 campaign in Bridgetown in June 2024.

There has been so much talk about whether one, or both, or neither, will be present at next year's 50-over World Cup in southern Africa that most other issues have been relegated to the background. Including the fact that there is another high-profile one-format-only international in recent times, a young man who has completed a decade in India colours but is now at a tenuous crossroads after an eminently forgettable last few months.

As India embarked on a journey of transition, replete with excitement and promise, last summer through a five-Test tour of England, it was expected that the future would be shaped by two of the most luminous gems in the Indian firmament. Shubman Gill's elevation to the Test captaincy was no surprise, even though he didn't have a great deal of leadership experience at the First Class level. Gill had time on his side, he was even then one of the top batters whose place wasn't under threat, and he had shown himself to be a quick learner. Thrust into the role of his deputy was a once-fearless force of nature who had been forced by circumstances to temper his exuberance, both because of extraneous pressure and owing to the fact that, having established himself as one of the seniors within the setup, he had to strike a fine balance between carefree and careless batsmanship.

Rishabh Pant's rise as the vice-captain of the Test side was welcomed with as much breathless anticipation as Gill's to the captaincy. Or Pant's arrival at the batting crease, if you like. With the chunky left-hander, you still don't know what to expect. Or maybe you do, but even so, what he does simply blows your mind. Pant isn't reckless; he isn't someone who doesn't not put a price on his wicket, though from time to time, 'Stupid, stupid, stupid' will surface because that's just who he is. Successive coaches, from Ravi Shastri to Rahul Dravid to now Gautam Gambhir, have given him the licence to be himself with the rider that he should be a little more selective, a little more game-aware, a little more respectful of situations and conditions.

It might have been tough for Gambhir to reconcile, for instance, to Pant's extravagant aerial drive to his fifth delivery, from off-spinner Ramesh Mendis, that nestled in long-off's hands at the NCC ground on Saturday in India's only practice game, against a Sri Lanka Cricket XI. Most other batters would have been happy to play themselves in, get some circulation going, get a feel of the conditions, prepare conservatively for the two-Test series beginning in Galle next Saturday. But Pant isn't most people, and that's precisely what makes him the compelling attraction in front of the stumps that he has been since his Test debut in August 2018.

Pant fell just two balls after attempting a similar stroke that fell just beyond the reach of the backtracking mid-off fielder, compelling Mendis and skipper Sonal Dinusha to push Nishan Madushka back. Perhaps in a show of bravado, or more likely because he backed himself to middle the ball turning away from him and comfortably clear the fielder, Pant went through with the stroke only to put the ball up in the air for Madushka to complete a smart grab. Two runs from

five deliveries isn't what Pant, or the leadership group of Gill and Gambhir would have hoped for, but as mentioned earlier, India have been willing to accept the trade-off because when Pant gets going, the destruction he can wreak is beyond parallel.

Pant's dalliance with the vice-captaincy didn't last too long, the decision-makers arriving at the conclusion that he and Indian cricket would be better off without additional responsibilities being thrust on his shoulders. In his first sojourn as Gill's deputy, Pant was a runaway success. His batting in England, on admittedly excellent tracks for batting, was a sight for sore eyes. While Gill was wooing and wowing the connoisseurs with his correctness and his silken stroke-making on his way to 754 extraordinary runs, Pant was at his innovative, unpredictable best without compromising on consistency. In Leeds during the first Test, he became the first Indian stumper to notch up twin hundreds in England, backed it up with 25 and 65 in the series-levelling win in Birmingham, produced efforts of 74 and 9 in the Lord's loss and won himself a few million more fans by coming out to bat with a broken foot in the first innings and making a stirring 54 in the fourth Test in Manchester.

On-field heroism

The manner in which he contracted that injury, and the events that followed as he took on-field heroism to a different level, are archetypal Pant. The 28-year-old attempted a reverse against seamer Chris Woakes and only managed to play the ball on to his foot, carried off the field as that part of his body swelled up dramatically within seconds of the impact. When he came out to bat, hobbling and unable to put any weight on his right foot, he still found enough timing and power to smack fours - and a six - as he brought up his fifty to raucous applause and walked off to warm appreciation and genuine respect from England's fielders.

That broken foot not only ended his England tour but also kept him out of the home series against West Indies in October. By this time, Pant was clearly only in the running for Test matches. His last ODI was in August 2024, his last T20I a week before that, both in Sri Lanka in Gambhir's first assignment as Dravid's successor. Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan in the shorter white-ball format, and K.L. Rahul and Kishan in the 50-over version, have surged well clear in the wicketkeeper-batter stakes, which means the only canvas available to Pant, apart from the IPL which hasn't been his happiest hunting ground, is the five-day spectacle.

Pant's return to Test cricket, against

South Africa in Kolkata in November, was anything but auspicious as India failed to hunt down 124 on an Eden minefield. Gill's batting efforts in that Test were restricted to just three deliveries in the first innings as he retired hurt with a neck injury, an affliction that kept him out of the second Test in Guwahati and thrust Pant into the Test skipper's role for the first time.

Hard times

It was a disastrous initiation; Pant himself played one of the most horrendous strokes of his career, a little after lunch on day three, then oversaw a 408-run hammering - India's heaviest by runs in Test history. A few months later came a campaign of gigantic failure in the IPL when, under Pant, Lucknow Supergiants hurtled from one misadventure to another. Even before the tournament had ended, Pant had stepped down as captain, and a few weeks later, it was confirmed that the IPL's most expensive player would return to his original franchise, Delhi Capitals, after taking a heavy pay cut.

Pant had a reasonably fruitful outing in the one-off Test against Afghanistan in New Chandigarh in June, with a somewhat restrained 81 in his, and India's, only innings of the game that they bossed all the way through. By then, though, he had been replaced as vice-captain by K.L. Rahul, one of the few individuals to have captained the country in all three formats, all in a stand-in capacity. It was the clearest indication that Agarkar's panel, if no one else, believed that Pant himself and the team as a whole would be better off if he was divested of official leadership responsibilities, though given his standing in the international circuit, Pant can't not be a leader in his own right.

Now, Pant can focus on his primary disciplines without having to attend lengthy team discussions or the distraction of being pulled in different directions, an inevitable fallout of additional role thrusts. Behind the stumps, he is unconventional and unorthodox, more Mahendra Singh Dhoni than Syed Kirmani or Nayan Mongia. In front of it, he is evidently in a league of his own. Like he showed on Sunday in Colombo, he can stonewall if so required - though even he will admit that he took it too far - and switch gears around his stonewalling without warning. It is exactly this unpredictability that makes him such an irascible force, a revolving door that can exasperate as much as it can exhilarate.

Impressive numbers

Despite the presence in the squad, and possibly in the playing XI, of Dhruv Jurel,

there is not even an artificial threat to Pant's presence in the Test scheme of things. After all, we are talking about someone who averages 43.37 from an even 50 Tests, at a jaw-dropping strike-rate of 74.05 embellished by eight centuries and 19 fifties in 87 innings. These are numbers that would do several specialist batters proud - remember that Mike Atherton and the recently retired Ajinkya Rahane both averaged less than 40 - and yet, there is more to Pant. Such as 162 catches and 16 stumpings, and the very rare ability to change the course of even Test matches with two hours of unadulterated mayhem.

Six of Pant's eight centuries have come away from home - four in England, and one each in Australia and South Africa - though like most of the rest of his colleagues, he hasn't played a Test match in Sri Lanka yet. In some ways, the conditions there will be strikingly similar to India, but in others, they won't be, especially when it comes to pace off the surface. Galle from Saturday, and the SSC ground the week thereafter, will ask questions of Pant that he hasn't been asked too often in the past, but knowing him, he will find the answers. How he uses those answers, however, will make for fun viewing, as much as how much and how freely he is allowed to use them. There is no point asking Pant to bat like Ravindra Jadeja because, well, he wouldn't be Pant then, would he? India need the most potent version of Pant to come to the fore. Only a really brave or stupid individual will bet against that eventuating.



THE GIST

Pant's rise as the vice-captain of the Test side was welcomed with as much breathless anticipation as Gill's to the captaincy. Or his arrival at the batting crease, if you like. With the chunky left-hander, you still don't know what to expect

In his first sojourn as Gill's deputy, Pant was a runaway success. His batting in England, on admittedly excellent tracks for batting, was a sight for sore eyes

The Tests in Galle and the SSC ground will ask questions of Pant that he hasn't been asked too often in the past, but knowing him, he will find the answers

If DNA is the instruction manual, we just opened a big second volume

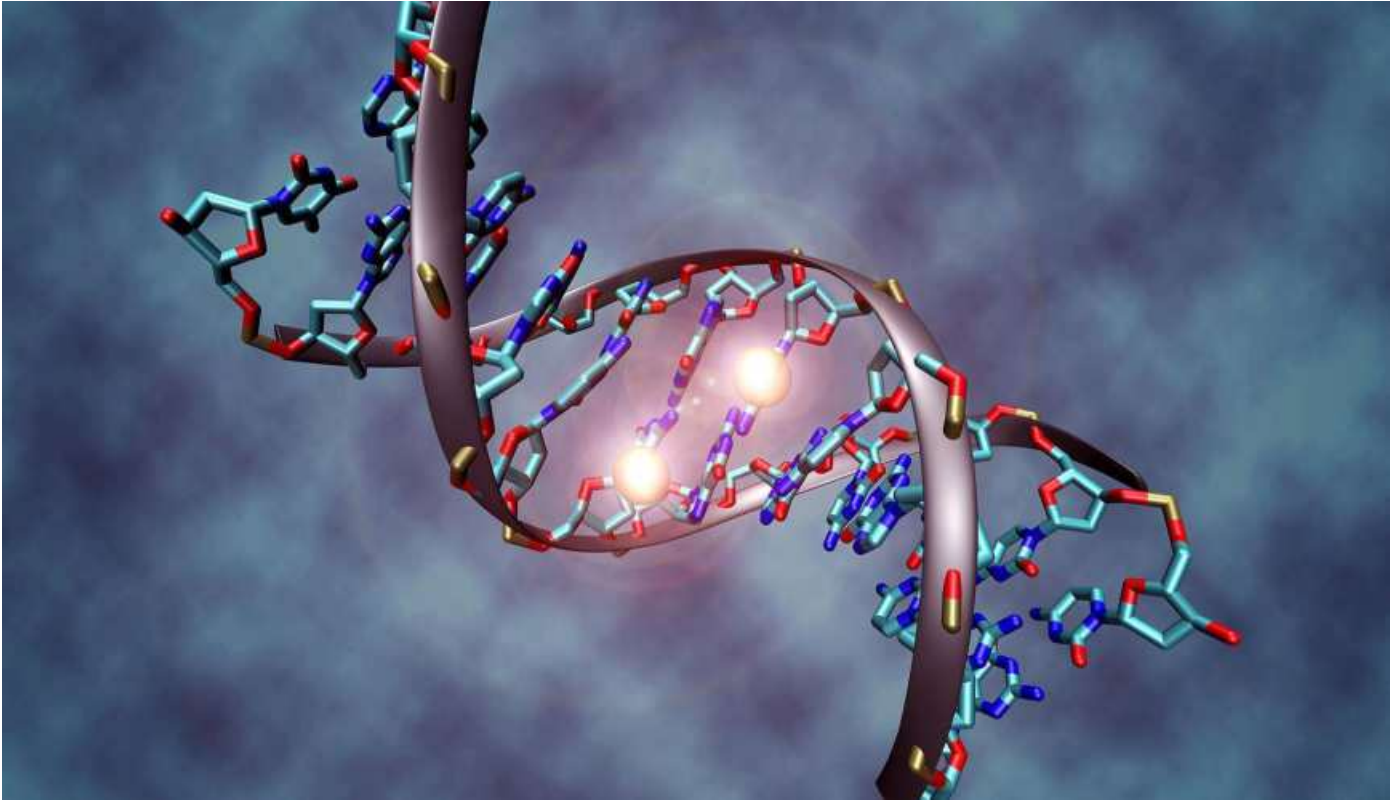
A new study found that several inherited traits occur not because genes mutate but because of chemical modifications of the genome that can jump across generations, change depending on whether an animal is male or female, and even copy themselves from one copy of a gene to another

D.P. Kasbekar

A team led by researchers at the Johns Hopkins School of Medicine has found that several inherited traits in the mouse genome break the rules Gregor Mendel laid down in the 19th century about how genes work. This is not because the genes mutate but because of chemical modifications of the genome that can jump across generations, change depending on whether an animal is male or female, and even copy themselves from one copy of a gene to another. Their findings were reported recently in *Nature Genetics*. While the study was in mice, the implications go far beyond – as the same mechanisms may also shape human health, and be able to explain conditions that have long resisted genetic analysis.

‘On’ and ‘off’ genes
Every cell in the body carries two kinds of genetic information. One is the sequence – the order of the four chemical bases, A, T, G, and C, that spells out which proteins a gene produces. This is the genome that geneticists have spent decades mapping. The other is about whether a small chemical compound – called the methyl group (-CH₃) – is attached to the DNA at specific locations. When cytosines are methylated, the gene is usually silenced. When the group is removed, the gene can be expressed again. This process of switching genes ‘on’ and ‘off’ without changing the underlying sequence is called epigenetic modification. Epigenetic modifications are not permanent. They can even differ between tissues – e.g. liver cells and muscle cells methylate differently. Many of them are also reversed when the body makes fresh sperm or eggs. The new study has found this rule to be violated.

Vastly underestimated
The researchers used a technology called nanopore sequencing. A single strand of DNA is threaded through a microscopic hole – the pore. As each base passes through, it produces a distinct blip in the electrical current flowing across the pore. Methylated cytosines produce a different blip from unmethylated ones. The team sequenced DNA from the liver and muscle tissues of mice belonging to two inbred strains. Their genomes differed at millions of positions. Of the 7,600 or so locations on the genomes where the methylation patterns differed, around 93% followed Mendel’s rules. That is, methylation had passed reliably from parent to offspring. But in the remaining 7% or so, the researchers identified more than 500 instances of



Representation of a DNA molecule that is methylated. The two white spheres represent methyl groups. They are bound to two cytosine nucleotide molecules that make up the DNA sequence. CHRISTOPH BOCK (CC BY-SA)
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>
The researchers also identified at least five new genes displaying genomic imprinting – where the level of methylation depends on whether the gene was inherited from the mother or the father. To illustrate, in 305 genome regions, all in the liver, the methylation depended on whether the mouse was male or female. Mendel’s rules don’t allow this. In 304 of these regions, females’ genomes were more methylated than males’ genomes. While sex-specific methylation in the liver has been reported before in both mice and humans, the new study found that the scale has been vastly underestimated.

A new first
The researchers also identified at least five new genes displaying genomic imprinting – where the level of methylation depends on whether the gene was inherited from the mother or the father. The most striking finding had to do with a phenomenon called paramutation. Here, the methylation status of one copy of a gene – say, the one inherited from the father – is also transferred to the other copy, inherited from the mother. The ‘rewritten’ mother’s copy then persists through the next generation. Again, scientists had observed paramutation in plants and engineered mice before. This is the first time it has been reported to be naturally occurring in a mammal’s genome. In the study, the paramutated gene was *Capn11*, which contains the recipe for a protein that is active in the testes during meiosis. When this protein is not available

but never to daughters. According to the study’s results, if a father carries a paramutagenic version of the gene that causes this condition and the mother carries a ‘normal’ version, then in a son the paramutagenic copy would rewrite the maternal copy, leaving the son to have hairy ears. He could then pass the paramutagenic variant of the gene to his own children. But if the paramutagenic variant is demethylated in females – as the new findings suggest can happen – a daughter’s own copies of the gene would be unmethylated and her ears would be unaffected. Even more broadly, the findings imply that genome-wide association studies – an increasingly popular kind of study that looks for the genetic variants linked to diseases – may be missing a significant fraction of heritable variation because that variation is not in the sequence. Instead, the study’s authors have argued the work opens the door to a new kind of analysis: allele-specific epigenome-wide association studies, which trace methylation patterns rather than sequence variants, to find parts of the genome associated with diseases that conventional methods miss. Human genetics has long assumed that if you sequence the genome, you have read the instruction manual. It may be that the manual has a second volume – and we have barely opened it today. (D.P. Kasbekar is a retired scientist. kasbekardp@yahoo.co.in)

Genome-wide association studies
The study also offers a new framework to explain heritable traits that researchers have struggled to study using genetics. For instance, a condition called hypertrichosis pinnae auris leads to the growth of coarse, dark hair on the outer ear and is prevalent among South Asian men. It is transmitted from fathers to sons

THE GIST

A team led by researchers at the Johns Hopkins School of Medicine has found that several inherited traits in the mouse genome break the rules Gregor Mendel laid down in the 19th century about how genes work. The study offers a new framework to explain heritable traits that researchers have struggled to study using genetics. The study’s authors have argued that the work opens the door to a new kind of analysis: allele-specific epigenome-wide association studies

BIG SHOT



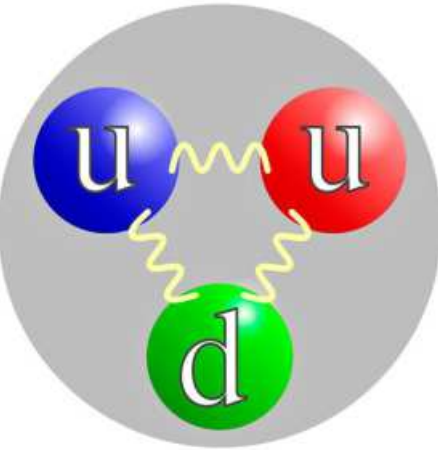
Workers prepare geo bags to prevent erosion of the Brahmaputra river bank at Borakhat village, in Kamrup district of Assam on August 7. ANI

WHAT IS IT?

Glueball: matter of force

Vasudevan Mukunth

Nature has four fundamental forces: gravity, the weak force (responsible for radioactivity), electromagnetism, and the strong force. The strong force is responsible for keeping the protons and neutrons together in the nuclei of atoms. The theory describing the strong interaction between two particles is called quantum chromodynamics (QCD). In QCD, the strong force is carried by gluons – just like how the electromagnetic force is carried by photons. But unlike photons, gluons carry a kind of charge that allows gluons to be attracted to each other. And QCD says they can come together to form composite particles called glueballs. In new research, scientists have taken a big step closer to showing glueballs exist. The team used data from the BESIII experiment in Beijing to uncover them. This is easier said than done because when a glueball appears in a particle physics experiment, it will be very short-lived and quickly decay into lighter particles in a way that is hard to distinguish from some other particles. Scientists had first observed a candidate glueball called X(2370) in BESIII data in 2011. Its mass seemed consistent with a glueball. They also estimated some of its properties based on the decays of a particle called the J/ψ meson. The new data buttresses the odds that



Protons are made up of three smaller particles called quarks, held together by the strong interaction mediated by particles called gluons. ARPAD HORVATH (CC BY-SA)

X(2370) is indeed a glueball by revealing more properties glueballs possess. Thus, BESIII has assembled the strongest case to date that X(2370) has a dominant glueball component, potentially providing the first evidence for a form of matter made just from the carriers of a fundamental force.

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